SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · BOOK 4

Share the Load

The work nobody sees, and
a fair, kind way to share it



by Christian

Christian's Lab
spreadloveandacceptance.com

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Free online, always. Every chapter of the series is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, in a short and a full version, with no account and no paid version. The print books are optional. You may copy pages of this book for personal use and for non-commercial teaching, with credit to "Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com".

Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence. None of them is a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed in short at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

Contents

About this book, and how to use it 4

Workpapers, tools and three friends 5

If you need help now 6

1 The work nobody sees: invisible labour at home 9

2 Is the split working? A fair look at chores at home 27

3 Full tanks and different angles: stress and perspective 49

4 Two kinds of fair: equal vs fair at home 69

5 The monthly look-back: a calm relationship check-in 93

After What the series adds up to 115

Your first month, week by week 121

A list of jobs to start from 123

Words for the talk 126

Questions people ask 127

Workpapers and tools in this book 129

How the numbers work 131

Words used in this book 138

Research notes 141

Free on the website 146

The series 148

Your notes 149

About this book, and how to use it

This book is about the work of sharing a life: the jobs nobody sees, a simple check of whether the way you share them can last, how much of a reaction is leftover stress, two kinds of fair, and a gentle monthly look back.

It is for anyone who shares a home, a family or a job, whether that is a couple, a family, housemates, co-parents or coworkers. Most of it also works if you are the only one reading.

Read the chapters in any order. Each is a short version of a chapter that is free to read online, where the full version has more research, more examples and more to try. The code at the end of each chapter opens it on your phone.

HERE	ABOUT	FREE ONLINE AT SPREADLOVEANDACCEPTANCE.COM/BOOK
Chapter 1	The work nobody sees	…/book/preface
Chapter 2	Is the split working?	…/book/chapter-2
Chapter 3	Full tanks and different angles	…/book/chapter-3
Chapter 4	Two kinds of fair	…/book/chapter-4
Chapter 5	The monthly look-back	…/book/chapter-5
Afterword	What the series adds up to	…/book/afterword

There are four books in the series, and each stands on its own. The others are Book 1, *Know Yourself Kindly*, about yourself; Book 2, *Heal and Steady*, about the heavy days; Book 3, *Understanding Each Other*, about understanding the people around you. When a chapter mentions another book, it gives the book, the chapter and the page in that book, as in "Book 2, Chapter 1 (page 9)". The workbook, The Workpapers, has every form from the series on big pages.

FIVE BIG IDEAS

Five ideas run under the whole series.

- **See the whole load.** Count the unseen work too, the noticing, remembering and planning, yours and other people's.
- **Fix the setup, not the person.** When something keeps going wrong, change the arrangement around it before you blame anyone.
- **Read your state first.** How full your day already is changes how every word sounds, so check yourself before you react.
- **Tune how you send and receive.** People differ in pace, tone and wiring, and a mismatch is something to translate, never a fault.
- **Notice the quiet incentives.** Jobs nobody owns drift to whoever notices first, and a named owner and a real thank-you stop the drift.

Some chapters mention the six-week program, a free plan on the website with one small step a week (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01). The workbook has a planner for it. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence.

Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-01 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as “Workpaper WP-01: Who did what”. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website, and the book gives a code to scan for each one. *The Workpapers: The Bound Edition* has them all in one place, on big pages.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as “Tool: Who does what? Quick look”. You use it and it gives you something back.

Workpapers and tools are kept in separate lists. Both are free and need no account, and what you type stays on your own device.

THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



Professor Puddles, the cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup, bounds in with a playful tip.



Sugarfoot, the steady, gentle pup, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

If you need help now

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number: 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

WHERE YOU ARE	CALL OR TEXT
United States	Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line).
United Kingdom	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line).
Ireland	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**.
Canada	Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French.
Australia	Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14.
New Zealand	Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?).
Anywhere else	**findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat.

For children and young people

UK	Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19)
Ireland	Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18)

Canada	Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868
Australia	Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25)
New Zealand	Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234
US	988 is for every age.

If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Book 3, Chapter 7, page 113 says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Book 2, Chapter 3, page 51 about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

1

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 1

The work nobody sees: invisible labour at home

Running a shared life takes a lot of work that nobody sees. This opening chapter helps you make that work visible, to yourself and to anyone you share it with, so that you can talk about it fairly and kindly.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Unseen work quietly adds up
2. A lot of it is thinking, not doing
3. The other person usually just hasn't seen it
4. Writing it down isn't keeping score
5. Each of you writes only your own side
6. The borrowed words are there to take the blame away
7. One small step at a time
8. It can help in many kinds of shared life
9. The mental load: what the research says
10. On your own: your own unseen work
11. One household, followed for a month
12. Your situation, chapter by chapter
13. Common mix-ups
14. Limits and cautions

IN SHORT

- **Running a home takes unseen work**, the noticing, remembering and planning that many people call the mental load.
- **The other person usually just hasn't seen it.** This work hides by nature, and missing it says little about how much someone cares.

- **Each of you writes only your own side** of one ordinary week, and you read the two lists together.
- **The list is for seeing.** Thank each other for the past, and plan next week.

SUNDAY, 9PM

Someone notices that the laundry is still in the washer, the school forms are due on Tuesday and the birthday card never got posted. They also notice that nobody else has noticed. From the hallway the house looks fine, and that is exactly the trouble.

Across town, a widower is finding out how many jobs his wife quietly carried, from the birthday cards and the boiler service to knowing who to ring when someone was ill. He never saw them until they stopped getting done.

01

Unseen work quietly adds up.

Remembering appointments, noticing that the milk is low and calming a tense moment never show up on a calendar, so they rarely get a thank-you, and over months they pile up. This book calls the pile *unbilled debt*, because nobody ever sends a bill for it. You can thank someone for what they carried before, and you leave the past unbilled. Marcus remembers every school form, dentist visit and bit of lunch money for their two children. His husband, Theo, sees two children who always seem to have what they need, because the work is out of his sight.

Tonight you could write down three things you did today that nobody saw, and leave the list alone for now. If you show it to someone later, something like “I’m not asking you to pay anything back. I just want you to see them” sets the right tone.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The easiest way to see unseen work is to write it down for one ordinary week. Each of you logs only your own jobs, and the thinking counts too.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-01 · free to print
Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

02

A lot of it is thinking, not doing.

Before a job gets done, someone has to notice it, remember it, plan it and check that it happened. That thinking takes real time and energy even though nobody can see it. In a shared flat, Yasmin notices that the internet deal is ending, compares plans, picks one and checks it went through. Paying took two minutes, and the thinking took her most of an evening.

Pick one job at home and split it into its steps, noticing, planning, doing and checking, and then ask who usually does each step.

The work nobody sees

Most of a job happens before and after the doing.

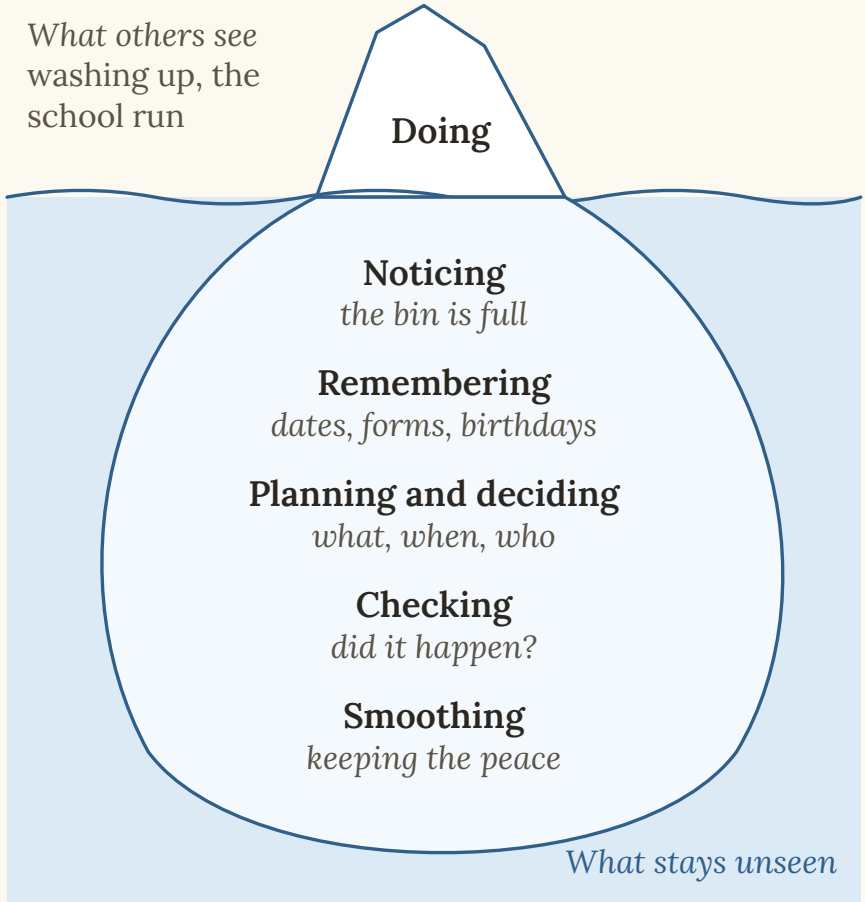


Illustration. The five kinds are this book's plain words; researchers call the thinking part "cognitive labour" (Daminger, 2019).

FIGURE 1 The work nobody sees. Most of a job happens before and after the doing, and whoever holds that part can never fully switch off.

03

The other person usually just hasn't seen it.

When this work is done well, nothing seems to happen, so the other person is rarely ignoring it. From where they stand, things appear to take care of themselves. Edna minds her grandchildren three afternoons a week and quietly moves her own doctor's appointments to fit, while her daughter believes it all fits in easily. A gentle question often opens it up, such as "What's something you do that you think I don't see?", followed by listening without explaining.

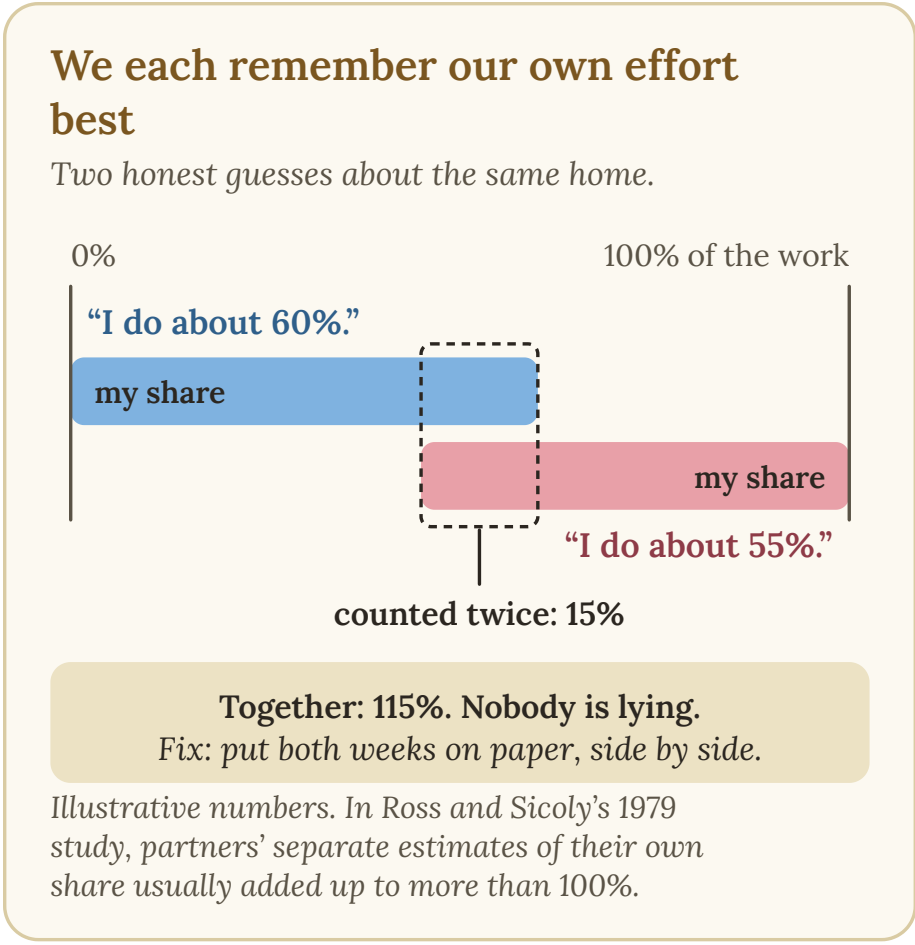


FIGURE 2 We each remember our own effort best. Illustrative numbers; in Ross and Sicoly’s 1979 study, partners’ estimates of their own share usually added up to more than 100 percent.

04

Writing it down isn’t keeping score.

The point is for both of you to see the same picture, in the same words, at the same time, so that the talk starts from facts you share. This book calls that shared record a *ledger*, a plain list of who did what, kept for seeing. Two coworkers who share one job each list a week of tasks and find that every client call has landed

on one of them. They leave last year alone and agree to swap the Friday calls.

Before you show anyone a list, ask yourself whether it is to plan next week or to prove a point, and share it only if the answer is planning.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

Who did what

Marcus and Theo, a couple

Who did what

Person A
Marcus

Person B
Theo

Week beginning
5 October 2026

Part A: Who did what, this week

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Mon	*Plan the week's meals*	*Theo*	20	*Thinking and planning*
Mon	*Cook dinner*	*Marcus*	45	*Asked for*
Tue	*Book the boiler service*	*Theo*	15	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Dishes*	*Marcus*	20	*Asked for*
Wed	*Laundry, wash to put away*	*Theo*	60	*Noticed and handled*
Thu	*Remember Marcus's mum's birthday card*	*Theo*	10	*Thinking and planning*

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Fri	*Bins and recycling out*	*Marcus*	*10*	*Noticed and handled*
Sat	*Big food shop*	*Both*	*70*	*Asked for*

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

Marcus
110 minutes (44%), of which 10 noticed and handled without being asked

Theo
140 minutes (56%), of which 105 noticed and handled without being asked (30 of them thinking and planning)

Workload balance score
0.88. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

Unasked-for work
Theo did 91% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no

Left blank this week.
Fill in your own: Who did what

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-01 · free to print
Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

05

Each of you writes only your own side.

Nobody fills in anything for the other person. You each note what you did and then read the two lists together, which keeps it fair and keeps it kind. Each of you also adds the context only you have, such as a long week at work or children off school with colds, so that you both understand what you read. Arran, Dani and Sol are three partners sharing a home, and each writes only their own list. Reading them together, Sol learns for the first time that Arran has been ringing the landlord every month.

06

The borrowed words are there to take the blame away.

The book uses a few terms from accounting and science because they describe what is happening without saying whose fault it is. Each one is explained in plain words, and you never need them to use anything here. Two brothers share their mum's care, and one of them swaps "You never help" for "There's some unseen work here we haven't looked at," which his brother finds much easier to hear. If words like "ledger" or "debt" feel heavy, use your own, since "our list" and "the stuff nobody sees" do the same job.

07

One small step at a time.

Each chapter adds one idea and one tool, and one week of notes is enough to start. Later come a 90-second daily check-in about how much you were carrying that day, a weekly catch-up and a monthly look-back, which needs only a few lines a week. A nurse on nights and a partner on days hardly see each other awake, so they start with one week of notes on the fridge and change nothing yet. Your first step can be as small as picking a start day this week and setting one reminder on your phone.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: counting jobs isn't keeping score. It's more like a treasure hunt for the work nobody noticed! The quick split check is a good first sniff.

TOOL **Who does what? Quick look** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand`

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Who does what? Quick look
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand`

08

It can help in many kinds of shared life.

Partners, families, roommates, co-parents and coworkers all share unseen work. The examples often use a couple at home, and the ideas fit anyone who shares a load. In a foster home, the carer tracks family visits, social worker calls and school meetings, while

a teenager in the home quietly cooks for the younger ones twice a week, and both kinds of work deserve to be counted.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't make anyone see the unseen work, and you can't write their side of the ledger. You can write your own side honestly, say it once, kindly, and then match what you take on to what comes back. If you keep carrying more than your share with nothing in return, stepping back towards your share isn't a punishment. It protects the energy you need to stay kind. More in Book 1, Chapter 2: who you are today (page 25)

FRIDAY, AFTER WORK

"You didn't have to do all that," they say, and they mean it kindly. You think that someone did have to. The list only ever lived in your head, so to them it looked as if it took care of itself.

The mental load: what the research says

Many people call the thinking side of home life the **mental load**, meaning the noticing and planning that come before a job gets done and the checking after. It includes knowing the baby needs the next size of clothes, and remembering the form, the jab and the party present. It is real work, even when it doesn't look like any.

Studies of couples find some patterns, *on average*. In couples of a man and a woman, women tend to do more of the noticing and checking (Allison Daminger, 2019). After a first baby a gap often opens, and in one study of working couples, mothers took on most of the new childcare while keeping their paid hours (Jill Yavorsky

and colleagues, 2015). Arlie Hochschild called the home work that starts after paid work ends "the second shift."

There is a fair point on the other side too. Sometimes the parent who knows how things are done holds on to that, without meaning to, which researchers call *gatekeeping*. When a parent openly invites the other in and lets them do it their own way, the other parent tends to do more of the care (Sarah Allen and Alan Hawkins, 1999; Sarah Schoppe-Sullivan and colleagues, 2008).

These are averages across many homes, and they say nothing certain about yours. In your home it may be the other way round, or already even, or shared between two men or two women, which is why the book asks you to look at your own week on paper instead of guessing.

Hollie and Gareth have a toddler and a baby, and Gareth works shifts. Their week's minutes come out nearly even, yet Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked anyone to do. Their week is in Chapter 2 (page 43).

> YOU COULD SAY
> "You do lots of the doing. It's the remembering I'd love you to take some of, whole jobs, start to finish." Or the other way round, "Show me once how you like it done, then let me do it my way."

On your own: your own unseen work

You don't need anyone else to start seeing the unseen. For one week, notice the jobs only you remember, such as the appointments, the restocking and the smoothing-over, and write them down for yourself. Count it without charging for it, since the point is to see your real load so that you can plan your energy.

Notice which jobs are yours by choice and which simply landed on you, and pick one you could hand back, drop or do less often. Nicola, divorced, has the children every other week, and on paper she sees that she still buys the presents for both sides of the family. She hands his side back in one friendly message. More for people living alone or after a breakup is on On my own.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/on-my-own

One household, followed for a month

Three adult siblings share the care of their father, who lives alone in the house they grew up in. On paper the visits are split evenly, two days each. When each of them writes a week of their own side, the picture changes. The eldest, Ffion, also holds the prescriptions, the hospital letters and the calls to the GP, none of which counts as a visit. Their brother is surprised and a little defensive, and the first conversation ends early. A month later they try again, and he takes over the prescriptions completely, with the reminders on his own phone. Their sister still finds the hospital letters too much to face, so Ffion keeps them for now, and they agree to look again in the spring. The ideas in this chapter fit friendships, teams and shared houses in the same way, and Help by relationship has a page for many kinds of shared life.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/by-relationship

Your situation, chapter by chapter

Some situations get their own section:

- **Faith, culture, elders and in-laws.** Book 3, Chapter 1 (page 9)
- **Small children or a new baby.** Chapter 2 (page 43)
- **Two homes after a split, and step-parents.** Chapter 3 (page 65)
- **Money between you, and a couple with a housemate.** Chapter 4 (page 85)
- **New together, or grandparents raising a grandchild.** Chapter 5 (page 108)

Common mix-ups

- **"If it mattered, they would have asked for help."** Unseen work is often hidden from the person doing it too, until it is written down.
- **"It has to be exactly 50/50."** The goal is a split you can both see and both agree to.
- **"We should start by going over the last ten years."** Start with one ordinary week. You can thank someone for the past without trying to settle it.
- **"The one doing less doesn't care."** Usually they just can't see it yet. Once you have both seen it, what you do next is a choice you make together.

To start, each of you can list the things you did this week that nobody saw, then swap lists, read the other one slowly and say one thing on it you hadn't noticed before. Pick one item from their list and say thank you for it in a specific way. If writing things down isn't your style, a ten-minute talk over a cup of coffee with the same questions works too. Fixing comes later, once you have both seen the same picture. Who did what turns this into a gentle week-long log, and How to say a specific thank-you has more ideas.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-01 · free to print
Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01



ONLINE
How to say a specific thank-you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward

Limits and cautions

These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about the split ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A list should never be demanded, checked over your shoulder, or used to keep track of where you go or what you spend. If that is happening, it isn't a ledger. It's control, and it's not your fault. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs). If you are a counsellor or group leader using this book with others, see For counsellors.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

ONLINE
Signs to look out for
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

ONLINE
For counsellors
spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Is the split working?
Putting the unseen work into numbers you both trust page 27

Book 3, Chapter 3 · How we see each other
Why each person sees their own work first Understanding Each Other, page 45

Book 3, Chapter 7 · Helping others well
Care work and how not to burn out Understanding Each Other, page 113

Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair
What fair means to each of you, before you talk page 69

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 1: see the work that's already happening
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

Who did what
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface-in-depth

2

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 2

Is the split working? A fair look at chores at home

One gentle question: can the way you share the work keep going, or is one of you quietly running on empty?

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Look at the month, not last night
2. Three things go in
3. Balance: how the hours split
4. Ownership: does each job have a name?
5. Stress: how full each stress tank is
6. One number comes out, from 0 to 1
7. Start with the biggest shortfall
8. It judges the setup, never a person
9. Words this chapter uses
10. On your own: is your own load working?
11. One setup, looked at twice
12. Common mix-ups
13. Small children and a new baby
14. If only one of you wants to try this
15. More for your situation

ANY GIVEN WEEK

One of you is quietly doing eleven small things a day that the other has never had to think about. When the other says it feels even, they mean it, because from inside their own week it does.

01

Look at the month, not last night.

When people ask whether the split is working, the answer usually comes from whatever happened most recently. This chapter asks a calmer question, using what you both wrote down. Ask it again

every few months, even when things seem fine, because a split that worked once can quietly go stale.

For example, two housemates had one awful week of dishes in May. The whole month, written down, showed three ordinary weeks and one exam week.

TRY THIS.

Put a short check in your calendar for about a month from now.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: one bad evening isn't the whole story. Give it a month, then run the check together, slowly, with a snack.

TOOL **Fair split check: this week** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Fair split check: this week
spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working

02

Three things go in.

The first is how evenly the hours are shared. The second is whether every regular job has a clear owner, from the job list in One owner per job. The third is how stressed each of you already is from everything else going on. A **workpaper** is one of the site's free fill-in worksheets, and you don't need any of them to start, since rough notes on paper work too.

YOU COULD SAY

"Let's each bring our own numbers, so neither of us has to guess."

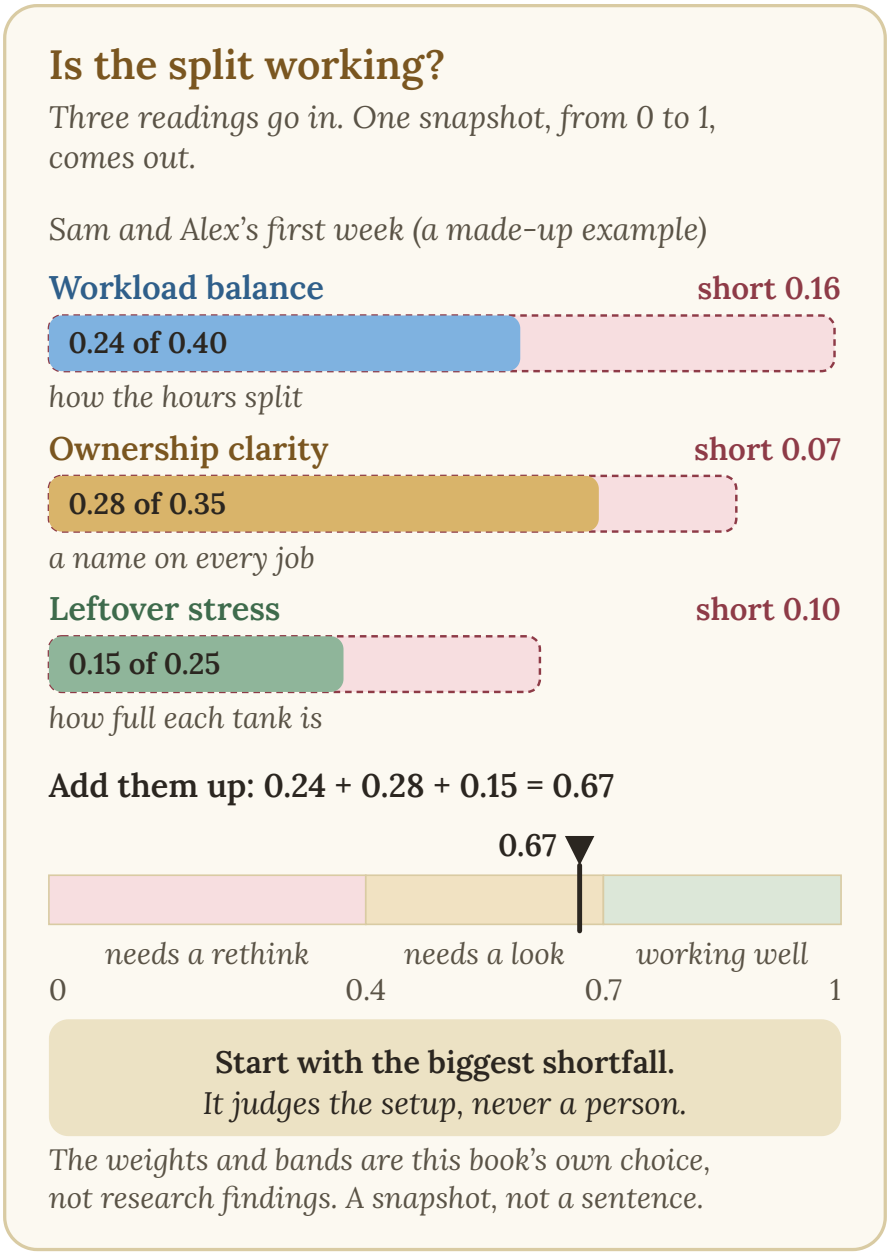


FIGURE 3 Is the split working? Three readings go in and one snapshot comes out. Start with the biggest shortfall. It judges the setup, never a person.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job

spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

03

Balance: how the hours split.

From your week-long logs, work out each person's share of the hours. An even split scores 1 and one person doing everything scores 0, whichever person it is. If you have agreed an uneven split that suits you, perhaps because one of you works longer hours outside the home, compare against that split instead. With three or more of you, compare each person's share with an even share (100 divided by the number of people) or with the split you agreed. Three partners who log 30 hours of home jobs between them, at 15, 9 and 6, would each have 10 as an even share. The "Who does what?" page, where each person lists their hours, does the arithmetic.

THIS WEEK.

Log one week each, and include the small jobs that take under ten minutes.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

Who does what? Quick look

Wren, Josh and Mei, housemates (Wren's view)

Quick look: who does what at home

Mark who mostly does each job. The picture builds as you go, the thinking work too.

Your name
Wren

Their name
Josh

Person 3
Mei

Job	Who mostly does it
Dishes	*Shared*
Laundry	*Shared*
Cleaning the bathroom	*Josh*
Cooking dinner	*Mei*
Grocery shopping	*Wren*
Paying bills	*Wren*
Noticing what's running low	*Wren*
Planning the week	*Mei*
Remembering dates and appointments	*Wren*

HOW IT LOOKS

Here's how it looks from your side, 9 jobs so far.

Everyday jobs: mostly shared. 6 jobs: Wren 2 · Josh 1 · Mei 1 · Shared 2.

Planning and remembering: mostly Wren. 3 jobs: Wren 2 · Mei 1.

The thinking work is easy to miss, because nobody sees it happen. Saying it out loud is a good start.

Does this match how it feels to the three of you?

Pets and booking appointments were taken off the list: they don't happen in this house.

Fill in your own: Who does what? Quick look

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL

Who does what? Count the hours and bills

spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand

04

Ownership: does each job have a name?

Each job gets two names. The owner does the job from start to finish, and the backstop notices if it slipped and checks in gently, which is very different from supervising. It can be the same person, though a second name gives the job a gentle check. Count the jobs that have an owner and divide by all the jobs on the list, and leave the jobs nobody owns on the list, because they matter most. A *decision* you make together, such as which school, can be

marked “Both (decide together)” and counts as owned, while a *job* that needs doing gets one name.

Two sisters care for their dad, and nobody owned his prescription, so for a fortnight each thought the other had ordered it.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> “Can we put a name next to this one, so it doesn’t fall between us?”



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

A job without a name tends to land on whoever notices first. Write one owner next to each job, and the guessing stops.

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

05

Stress: how full each stress tank is.

Each of you rates how full your own stress tank is with How much are you carrying?, where a higher score means more stress. Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 up to 0.60 is moderate, and 0.60 or more is high. The score uses the average of your two scores, but if either of you is at 0.60 or more, talk about that first, even when the overall result looks fine. A setup that only works when you are both well rested can’t last, so more stress lowers the result. A grandmother

raising two grandchildren scores 0.70 while her son, who helps at weekends, scores 0.35, and her 0.70 is the headline.

ONE SMALL STEP.

Each of you scores your own tank on the same day, before looking at the other's.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

06

One number comes out, from 0 to 1.

A result of 0.70 or above reads as *working well*, meaning the setup is holding. From 0.40 up to 0.70 it reads as *needs a look*, because something is drifting, often who owns what, and below 0.40 it reads as *needs a rethink, together*. The result is called the setup score. It is a simple weighted sum, in which the hours count most, then the owners, then stress, and although it looks like a probability it isn't one. Two friends who run a café together score 0.55, which tells them nothing is broken and something is drifting.

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Write the date next to your number, so you can compare next month.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

Is the setup working for everyone?

Rosemary and Ken, retired, married 41 years

Is the setup working for everyone?

Person 1 (optional)
Rosemary

Person 2 (optional)
Ken

1. How the hours split

From Who did what or the "Who does what?" page: each person's total hours for the week.

Rosemary, hours
14

Ken, hours
10

2. Does each job have a name?

From One owner per job.

Jobs on the list
12

Jobs with an owner
9

3. How much each person is carrying

Each person's own score from How much are you carrying? Everyone fills in their own.

Rosemary, load (0 to 1)
0.45

Ken, load (0 to 1)
0.30

HOW THE SETUP IS WORKING

Working well
0.75 of 1. The setup is carrying its own weight.

Next: nothing in the setup needs changing this week. Keep the same rhythm of check-ins.

If you want to nudge it higher one day (optional, not urgent): hand about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken, and balance would go from 0.83 to 1.00. Give one more job an owner (the person who does it and sees it through), and ownership would go from 0.75 to 0.83.

It scores the setup, never a person, and never the relationship as a whole.

Fill in your own: Is the setup working for everyone?

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Fair split check: this week
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/calculators/is-the-setup-working-quick

07

Start with the biggest shortfall.

The single number matters less than which of the three parts pulled it down most. The **shortfall** is how far one part fell below the most it could add, and in the middle band it is often ownership, which is why the calculator suggests One owner per job first. Separated parents score 0.62 and find that their biggest gap is that nobody owns the school forms, so that is the only thing they change this month.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"Which part pulled the number down most? Let's start there."

08

It judges the setup, never a person.

The number isn't a verdict on who's better or whether the relationship works. It's where a conversation starts, never how one ends. These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about the split ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? lists free, private hotlines.

For example, one partner sees 0.35 and says, "So I'm the problem." The other says that the bathroom has no owner and that he works nights, and they start there.

TRY THIS.

Before you start, agree that either of you can say "pause" and come back later.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/safety

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. The score describes the setup you share, but your levers are your own: your jobs, your hours and what you agree to take on. You can propose a fix; you can't make the other person accept it. If the balance stays one-sided, step your load back towards your share on purpose, and say so kindly. Matching effort with effort protects your stress tank, and your tank is part of the score too. More in Book 1, Chapter 2: who you are today (page 25)

SUNDAY EVENING

Two week-long logs and two cups of tea sit on the table. One list has 31 rows and the other has 18, and for a moment nobody says anything. Then one of you says, "I honestly didn't know about half of these."

Words this chapter uses

A **log** is a simple list of the jobs you did this week and roughly how long each took. The **owner** does a job from start to finish, including remembering it, and the **backstop** notices if a job slipped and checks in gently. Your **stress tank** is how much stress you are already carrying from the rest of life. The **setup** is the way you share the work right now, which can always be changed, and the **setup score** is the one number from 0 to 1 that sums up the three readings. Invisible jobs count too. Planning meals, remembering birthdays, booking the vet and noticing that the soap is running low all belong in your log.

On your own: is your own load working?

You can ask the same question about your own week, which is whether you are spending more energy than comes back. Add up what you carry, the jobs, the people and the worries, and set it beside what refills you, such as rest, help and people who give back. If it runs in the red, change your side by dropping, delaying, asking or saying no kindly. A limit describes your supply, and it says nothing about your worth. After a breakup, Leanne has her children every other week and fills the quiet weeks with favours for friends, and writing it down shows her that she never rests (more in On my own).

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'd love to help, and I can't this week. Can I let you know next week?"

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/on-my-own

One setup, looked at twice

Three people share a flat above a bakery, and everyone agrees that cleaning matters while nobody owns the bathroom. Their first check scores 0.48, and the shortfall is plainly ownership, since eight of the twelve jobs have a name and the bathroom, the bins and the recycling don't. They give each of those jobs an owner and a backstop. A month later the score is 0.66. The bathroom is better

and the recycling is still a sore point, because the one who owns it works late on collection night, and that is the job they talk about next. Shift work, illness and caring can all make hours look even while sleep or energy is not, and an uneven split agreed on purpose can be the fair one (see Different hours and When one of you is ill).

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

Our room agreement

Kayla and Bea, first-year roommates

Our room agreement

Your name
Kayla

Their name
Bea

Quiet hours
11 pm to 7 am on weeknights, midnight on Fridays and Saturdays. Headphones after that.

Guests (daytime)
Fine with a quick text first. Not during the other one's study or sleep time.

Overnight guests
Up to 2 nights a week, agreed the day before. A guest doesn't stay in the room when their host isn't there.

Cleaning
Kayla: floor and bins, Sunday. Bea: desk area and the fridge, Wednesday. Our own laundry, our own job.

Borrowing
Ask first, every time. Food on the shared shelf is for both of us.

Lights and alarms
Big light off by 11:30 on weeknights; a desk lamp is fine. One alarm, one snooze at most.

How we bring up problems

Text first if that's easier, then talk within a few days, one topic at a time. If we're stuck, we ask our RA to help.

YOUR AGREEMENT, READY TO SEND

Our room agreement (Kayla and Bea), with every line above, ending: "We'll look at it again together in a month."

They kept most of the site's starting point and changed two lines.

Fill in your own: Our room agreement

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours

ONLINE
When one of you is ill
spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill

ONLINE
Our room agreement
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

Common mix-ups

- **"A low number means the relationship is failing."** It means the current setup needs changing, and setups change all the time.
- **"We can just guess the numbers."** A guessed number is a feeling with a decimal point, so use your written logs.
- **"One of us can fill it in for both."** Each person writes their own log and scores their own stress tank.
- **"Fair means exactly 50/50."** Fair is what you both agree to, with your eyes open, and an uneven split you chose together can be fair. Two kinds of fair (Chapter 4, page 69) looks at this.

Small children and a new baby

Small children bring a flood of new jobs, and most of them are thinking jobs, such as the nursery bag, the jabs, the party invitations, the next size of clothes and the night wakings. That is why the mental load (see the work nobody sees (Chapter 1, page 19)) often grows after a baby arrives, usually without anyone deciding it. Log the children's jobs too, with the thinking time, and count the nights. Hand over whole jobs, such as the clothes and sizes or the GP and the jabs, so that the new owner does the noticing too, in their own way. If a baby is on the way, write your first job list together before the birth, plan the nights and agree to look again at six weeks, at three months and before either of you goes back to work. In the first weeks, share by energy more than by hours, so that whoever was up in the night gets the rest.

Hollie and Gareth have Alfie, who is three, and Poppy, who is eight months old, and Gareth is a paramedic on shifts. Their logged minutes come out nearly even, yet Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked for. They leave the minutes alone and move one whole job, the children's clothes, to Gareth.

YOU COULD SAY

"Could you own the nursery bag from now on, including noticing when we're low on nappies? I won't check it."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

Who did what, with small children

Hollie and Gareth, parents of a toddler and a baby; Gareth works shifts

Who did what

Person A
Hollie

Person B
Gareth

Week beginning
12 October 2026

Part A: Who did what, this week

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Mon	*Pack the nursery bag: spare clothes, nappies, named milk*	*Hollie*	10	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Book Poppy's one-year jabs at the GP*	*Hollie*	15	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Bath and bedtime, both children*	*Gareth*	45	*Asked for*

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Wed	*Reply to a party invite and buy the present*	*Hollie*	25	*Noticed and handled*
Wed	*Sort outgrown clothes and order the next size*	*Hollie*	40	*Noticed and handled*
Thu	*Plan the week's meals around Gareth's nights*	*Hollie*	20	*Thinking and planning*
Thu	*Cook dinner and batch-cook for the weekend*	*Gareth*	75	*Noticed and handled*
Fri	*Remember the nursery photo money and form*	*Hollie*	10	*Thinking and planning*
Fri	*Night wakings with Poppy*	*Hollie*	60	*Noticed and handled*
Sat	*Swimming lesson with Alfie*	*Gareth*	60	*Asked for*
Sat	*Big food shop and nappies*	*Both*	80	*Asked for*
Sun	*Washing for both children, to put away*	*Hollie*	50	*Noticed and handled*
Sun	*Fix the stair gate*	*Gareth*	20	*Noticed and handled*
Sun	*Update the family calendar and the childcare rota*	*Hollie*	20	*Thinking and planning*

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

Hollie
290 minutes (55%), of which 250 noticed and handled without being asked (50 of them thinking and planning)

Gareth
240 minutes (45%), of which 95 noticed and handled without being asked

Workload balance score
0.91. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

Unasked-for work
Hollie did 72% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no

Left blank this week.

Gareth worked three night shifts this week, so his rows are fewer; the minutes are close, and the noticing is the part to talk about.

Fill in your own: Who did what

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-01 · free to print
Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

If only one of you wants to try this

That is common, and you can still start. Log your own week, score your own tank and then share one small thing you noticed, without asking the other person to agree with your numbers. A dad noticed he spent five hours a week driving his teenage son around, said so without any accusation, and they agreed on a bus pass for two days a week. Share one finding at a time and then let it rest for a few days.

If the other person refuses to talk about the split at all, ever, or makes you feel afraid for raising it, that isn't a setup problem. Please read Not safe at home?

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/safety

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Look at the month, not last night**, using what you both wrote down.
- ✓ **Three things go in**, which are how the hours split, whether each job has a name, and how full each person's stress tank is.
- ✓ **One number comes out, from 0 to 1.** Start with whichever part pulled it down most.
- ✓ **It judges the setup, never a person**, and it is where a talk starts.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 1 · The work nobody sees
The unseen work the check counts
page 9

Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles
The stress input, explained
page 49

Book 2, Chapter 6 · Habits and change
Fixing the setup with small, kind changes
Heal and Steady, page 105

Book 3, Chapter 7 · Helping others well
When one person carries the care
Understanding Each Other, page 113

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 2: give every job one owner
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

One owner per job
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2-in-depth

3

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 3

Full tanks and different angles: stress and perspective

Why some reactions are bigger than what caused them, and why two people can see the same moment so differently.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. A full tank overflows
2. Some stress is left over from earlier
3. Check your stress tank in a minute
4. Three everyday states
5. There are seven angles on the same moment
6. Both views can be true
7. Say it instead of making each other guess
8. A full tank means "later," not "never."
9. Words this chapter uses
10. On your own: reading your own tank
11. Common mix-ups
12. Two homes: co-parenting after a split
13. If only one of you wants to try this
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **A full tank overflows**, so stress left over from earlier makes small things feel big.
- **Check your tank in a minute**, and say the band out loud so nobody has to guess.
- **Two people can see one moment from different angles**, and both views can be true.
- **A full tank means later**, so pause, name a time and come back.

THURSDAY, 5:15PM

They ask, perfectly pleasantly, whether you remembered to call the dentist. Your answer comes out much bigger than the question deserved, and you can hear it happening while it happens.

01

A full tank overflows.

If you are already tired, stretched or stressed from somewhere else, a small question can get a big reaction, which is simply human. Anything decided in that moment is worth coming back to once you have both calmed down. A nurse gets home after a night shift and her housemate asks whether she saw his message, and she snaps at him. Twelve hours on her feet did the snapping, and the message just happened to come at the end of them.

YOU COULD SAY

"Sorry. That was bigger than the question. I'm running on empty."

02

Some stress is left over from earlier.

Ask yourself how much of this feeling is about the thing in front of you and how much you brought in with you. Being upset about the dishes and being exhausted, with the dishes as the thing you noticed, are different problems. Some of what we bring in is much older, such as an understanding from growing up that whoever notices the mess has to clean it, and if a feeling seems a lot older than the moment, Where your lens came from helps you find where it started.

For example, a teenager has a hard day at school, comes home and explodes because his brother took the phone charger, which was the last drop in a tank that was already full.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I think I brought this in with me. Give me ten minutes."



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Before a hard talk, check how full your own tank is. Five quick questions, about two minutes, and you'll know whether now is the time.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · free to print · spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Old rules, new choices
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up



WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

03

Check your stress tank in a minute.

How much are you carrying? measures how full your stress tank is, and a higher score means more stress in the tank. Score five things from 0 to 4, which are sleep, work elsewhere, any unsettled argument, how your body feels and time pressure today, then add them up and divide by 20. Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 up to 0.60 is moderate and 0.60 or more is high. If it has been high for a long time it can start to feel normal, so a quick reading each week is worth it. A man caring for his wife after

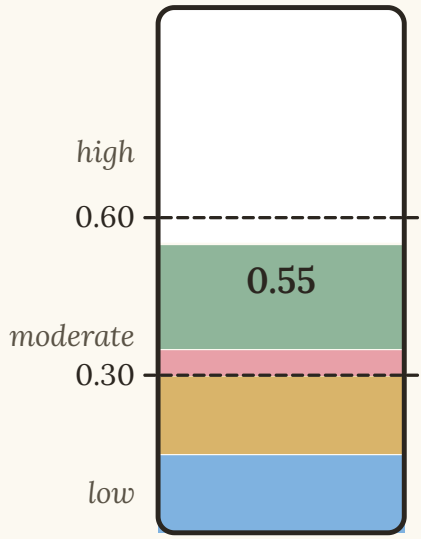
surgery scores 0.65 three days in a row, which tells him he needs help more than he needs to try harder.

TRY THIS.

Score yourself tomorrow morning, before you look at your phone.

How full is your stress tank?

Score five things from 0 to 4. Add them up, divide by 20.



Sam today

Time pressure today	4
Body: hungry, unwell, in pain	0
Unresolved conflict	1
Workload elsewhere	3
Sleep debt	3
11 ÷ 20	= 0.55

Moderate: say it before a hard talk.
"*Heads up, I'm carrying more than usual today.*"

Made-up example from this chapter. The five items and bands are this book's, not a tested questionnaire.

FIGURE 4 How full is your stress tank? Five things scored 0 to 4, added up and divided by 20. The scores shown are an example; the items and bands are this book's.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

How much are you carrying?

Rosa, who shares her mum's care with her brother

How much are you carrying?

Fill this in on your own, about yourself only. Never fill it in for someone else.

Your name

Rosa

Date

7 October 2026

The checklist

0 = Not at all · 4 = Very true

Sleep debt (less rested than usual)

0 1 2 (3) 4

Workload elsewhere (job, school, caregiving)

0 1 2 3 (4)

Recent unresolved conflict (any source)

0 (1) 2 3 4

Physical state (hungry, sick, in pain)

0 1 (2) 3 4

Time pressure today specifically

0 1 2 (3) 4

YOUR LOAD SCORE

Your load today
High load (13 out of 20 points)

What to do
Put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour. If you need to settle first, the Calm-Down Kit is made for this.

If it can't wait
If what you're carrying can't wait, like caring for someone who is ill, that's a sign to get more help, not to try harder: ask one person for one specific thing this week, and look into respite care.

Filled most by
sleep debt, workload elsewhere, time pressure today. Conditions, not character.

Load score
0.65 out of 1.00

Optional

☑ Some of what I'm carrying is caring for someone

Anything you want to name before talking
Mum's hospital appointment moved to Thursday, and I'm the one driving.

Higher means more load. Rosa scores only herself; her brother fills in his own.

Fill in your own: How much are you carrying?

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

04

Three everyday states.

Knowing whether you are calm and connected, revved up or running on empty tells you whether now is a good time to talk. The Nervous System Ladder, a thirty-second self-check, helps you make a best guess. The labels come from polyvagal theory, whose main claims are still debated by scientists, and here they are used only as everyday words. In one long-distance couple, he takes the video call at midnight his time and is often running on empty, so they move the hard talks to weekend mornings.

THIS WEEK.

Find one body clue for each state, such as a tight jaw for revved up.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
The Nervous System Ladder
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

05

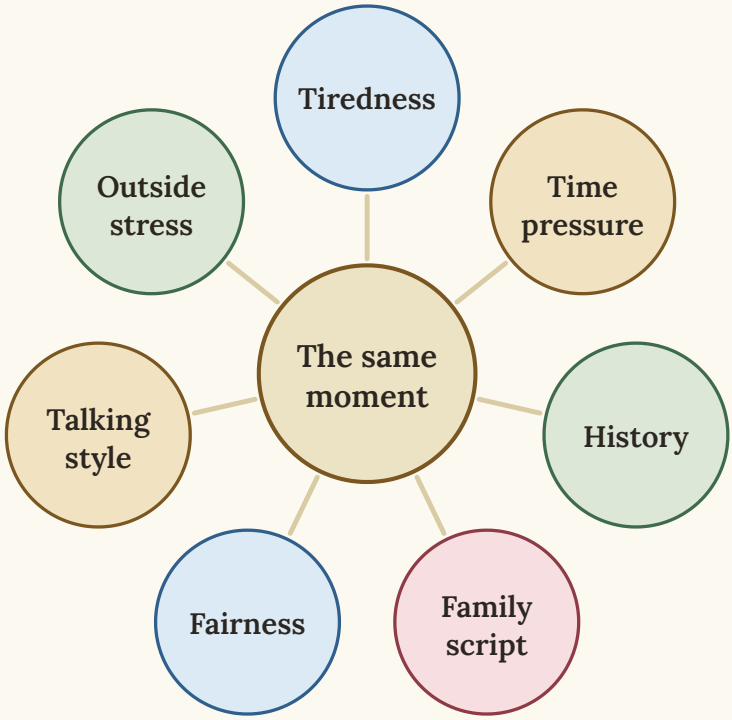
There are seven angles on the same moment.

The seven angles are tiredness, time pressure, history, what home was like growing up, your sense of fairness, how you communicate and stress from outside. Many arguments are two people looking from different angles, each sure that the other sees what they see. The “See their side” step of Rewind the talk is built on these seven angles and helps you picture how the same moment might look from the other side, with questions to ask in place of guesses. Planning the holidays, one parent sees it from family habit, since they always go to her mum’s, and the other sees it from fairness, since they went there last year too.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
>
> “Which angle are you seeing this from?”

Seven angles on the same moment

Which one are you looking from right now?



An angle is a place to stand, not a verdict.
Name your own. Ask about theirs.

Illustration. The seven angles are this book's; the Rewind the talk's "See their side" uses them.

FIGURE 5 Seven angles on the same moment. An angle is a place to stand, not a verdict: name your own, and ask about theirs.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

Rewind the talk: see their side

Hana, about her friend Lou

See their side

1. What happened?

I asked Lou if she was still coming to my birthday dinner, and she just replied "maybe".

2. Who are they to you?

Partner Family Roommate *Friend* Coworker Co-parent

My teen or child Someone else

3. What state might they have been in?

Calm and connected Revved up *Running on empty* I'm not sure

4. What might have been going on around them?

A long or hard day *Little sleep* Rushed or late Money worries

Caring for someone Not feeling their best A noisy or crowded place

Other people were there *It was a text or message* It was late at night

5. How are they wired?

They notice tone a lot They take words literally

They need time to process They think out loud They're very direct

They hint rather than say They like a plan

Noise, light or crowds get to them Their language or culture differs

6. What history might they carry?

This has come up before They grew up with it done differently

It's a sore topic for them They may feel it's unfair

7. What could each of you see? They may have seen or known things you didn't

their whole day and workload | *a message, call or news you didn't see*

something they had already planned or done

how it looked from where they stood | a promise someone else made them

how they were feeling inside

You may have seen or known things they didn't

the planning you had already done | *the reason behind your timing*

what you actually meant | how tired or stretched you were

the part already done | a deadline only you knew about

Neither of you could fully see

each other's tone, in writing | what was going on in the other's head

what would happen next | what other people had said to each of you

THROUGH THEIR EYES

Running on empty: If they were running on empty, short replies and slow answers are what a tired body does. It can look like not caring when it's only having nothing left.

Caring for someone: Caring for someone else uses up attention you can't see. They may have had less to give than usual.

Questions to check, instead of guessing: "How was your day, before this came up?" "Would it help to think about it and come back to it later?"

A sentence to bridge the gap: "I think we may have been seeing this from different places. On my side, I knew about the reason behind my timing, and I'm not sure that came across. I'm wondering whether, for you, you were running on empty. Could we compare notes? I'd like to understand how it looked to you."

These are possibilities to check, not facts about Lou.

Fill in your own: Rewind the talk: see their side

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Rewind the talk
spreadloveandacceptance.com/perspective-shifter

06

Both views can be true.

You can each be right about what you see and still be looking at different parts of the same thing, so the useful question is which angle each of you is seeing it from. Two adult brothers argue about their late mother's house, because one sees thirty years of memories and the other sees a roof that needs £9,000 of work, and both are looking at the real house.

WORDS TO TRY

"You're right about what you see. Can I tell you what I see?"

07

Say it instead of making each other guess.

Before a hard conversation, each of you says how full your stress tank is and which angle you are seeing things from. It works best at the start. Two coworkers begin a tense meeting with one sentence each about their tank and their angle, and the meeting is shorter and calmer than the last one.

YOU COULD SAY

"Before we start, I'm about half full today, and I'm seeing this from the time angle."



TIDBIT

Tidbit's tip: say your number out loud, like "I'm a seven today." It's quick, and nobody has to guess!

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

08

A full tank means "later," not "never."

A high score is a reason to pause and never a way out of the talk. Say when you will come back, and let the Calm-Down Kit help in the meantime. After your calming steps, check your tank again. Under 0.50, go back at the time you said. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round if you still feel hot, and if you are still at 0.60 or more after two rounds, pick a new time and say when. A dad and his fourteen-year-old get heated about phone time. He tells her he is too wound up and will talk at seven, and at seven he knocks on her door.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I need a break. I'll come back at seven. I promise."

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. Your stress tank is the only one you can empty. You can't calm someone else's tank for them, and pouring yours into theirs leaves two empty tanks. Protect yours: rest, say "later," and give energy where it's met. When both tanks are full, the kindest thing you control is the timing. More in Book 1, Chapter 2: who you are today (page 25)

MONDAY MORNING

You both look at the same pile of post on the kitchen table. One of you sees a to-do list, and the other sees proof that nobody else ever opens the post. You try saying your angles out loud, and it helps for about a minute before the old argument about the gas bill comes back. The pile is still there at lunchtime, and neither of you has decided whose it is.

Words this chapter uses

Your **stress tank** is how much stress you are already carrying before this moment even starts. **Leftover stress** is the part of a feeling you brought in from somewhere else, like poor sleep or a hard day, while **this-moment stress** is caused by what is in front

of you right now. An **angle** is the point of view you are seeing a moment from, such as tiredness or fairness.

On your own: reading your own tank

On your own, the most useful habit is a one-minute reading of your tank before you react. Check it for a few mornings in a row and look for a pattern, ask yourself before a hard moment how much of it is left over from earlier, and decide on a calm day what settles you so that it is ready when you need it. Living alone after a breakup, Bryony noticed that she snapped at her sister every Monday, and her morning readings showed why, since Sunday nights were her worst sleep of the week. Now she asks for Tuesday instead (see On my own).

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

Common mix-ups

- **"A big reaction means it was a big deal."** Sometimes it does, and often it means the tank was already full.
- **"A high score is an excuse."** It is a note to come back later and never a pass to skip the talk.
- **"I can tell how full their tank is."** Only they can say, since each person scores only themselves.
- **"Pausing is the same as the silent treatment."** A pause has a time to come back, which is why you always say when.

Two homes: co-parenting after a split

Children carry two homes, and changeover day fills their tank, so being quiet, clingy or cross for a few hours after a handover is common and usually says nothing bad about the other home. It helps to give them landing time, with a snack, something familiar and no questions about the other home for the first hour. The child is never the messenger, because adult news goes adult to adult. For money, follow any formal arrangement, split the extras by a ratio you agree, keep one list and settle up once a month. With an ex, share the band and keep the story, as in "I'm in a heavy week. Could we swap Wednesday?", and your private life stays yours. If an ex won't cooperate but isn't dangerous, parallel parenting can work, with written messages only, short and business-like, handovers at school and your own list for your own home. When there are new partners, the parent stays the owner of anything involving the other home, and a step-parent starts as a friendly adult rather than the one who tells the children off.

Harriet gives Freya, who is eight, and Arlo, who is five, an hour of toast and blankets when they come back from their dad's, and she has stopped asking what happened at Dad's at the front door. Sunday evenings are calmer, though Arlo still cries at bedtime on changeover days, and she is waiting to see whether that eases.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE (A BUSINESS-LIKE MESSAGE)
> "Hi Dylan. Freya's school trip is on 6 November and costs £24. I've paid it and put it on the extras list. Thanks, Harriet."

If you are afraid of your ex, a shared plan isn't the right tool: see Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

If only one of you wants to try this

You can do all of this on your own side, by checking your own tank, naming your own angle and pausing and coming back on time. The other person doesn't have to use the words for it to help, and when one person starts saying it out loud, the other often starts to as well. A daughter visits her dad every Sunday, and every week they clash over his health. She starts each visit by saying she is a bit tired today, so if she goes quiet it isn't about him. He never scores anything himself, and the visits still get calmer.

> **A note on safety:** A full tank explains a reaction. It never excuses shouting, threats or hurting anyone. If someone's "stress" often turns into fear for you, that isn't a tank problem. These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If sharing how you feel ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? lists free, private hotlines.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/safety

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 2, Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system
The ladder, flooding and rest
Heal and Steady, page 9

Book 3, Chapter 3 · How we see each other
The angles and stories behind a reaction
Understanding Each Other, page 45

Book 2, Chapter 2 · Anger
What to do in the hot minutes
Heal and Steady, page 31

Book 1, Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words
Checking your own weather first
Know Yourself Kindly, page 25

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 3: notice how much each of you is carrying
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

How much are you carrying?
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3-in-depth

4

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 4

Two kinds of fair: equal vs fair at home

Agree on what "fair" means before you argue about it, and give a comment a moment to land before you answer it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. There are two kinds of fair
2. Fair by results
3. Fair by promises
4. Once a job has an owner, look to the owner
5. Covering is kind. Say it out loud
6. Let a comment land before you react
7. Notice, name, decide
8. Keep the two questions apart
9. On your own: your own kind of fair
10. Common mix-ups
11. Money between you
12. A couple and a housemate
13. More for your situation
14. A note on safety

THE SAME ARGUMENT, TWICE A MONTH

One of you counts hours, and the other counts who noticed that the job needed doing. You are both counting honestly, in two different currencies, and then arguing about the exchange rate.

01

There are two kinds of fair.

One kind asks whether everything got done, and the other asks whether each person did what they said they would. Both are reasonable, and friction starts when each of you is using a different one without realising. Nisha and Kezia share a room in halls. Nisha thinks a week is fair if the room is tidy by Friday,

whoever tidies it, while Kezia thinks it is fair if each of them keeps their own half clean.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "When you say fair, do you mean it all gets done, or that we each do our bit?"

Two kinds of fair

Both are reasonable. Trouble starts when you use different ones without saying so.

Fair by results

Asks: Did it all get done?

Guards: Will the home keep running?

Good: flexible. Watch: it can hide who always steps in.

- Bins ✓
- Dentist ✓
- Forms ✓

Fair by promises

Asks: Did each of us do what we agreed?

Guards: Can I rely on you?

Good: clear. Watch: it can feel rigid in a hard week.

- Bins · Sam ✓
- Dentist · Maya ✗
- Forms · Lin ✓

The agreement: look to the owner

Bins · owner: Sam

second name: Alex, who notices and asks once

Once a job has a named owner, judge it by whether the owner did their part (swapping or asking ahead counts), not by whether someone quietly covered. Made-up examples.

FIGURE 6 Two kinds of fair. Both are reasonable; trouble starts when people use different ones without saying so. Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.

02

Fair by results.

This kind of fair judges by outcomes, by whether the right things got done by whoever had the time or energy. It is flexible and easy-going. Done carefully it counts the cost to whoever covered, and done carelessly it can hide who is always stepping in. A grandmother raising her grandchildren has a grown-up son who helps wherever it is needed when he is home. The house runs, and she is always the one who notices what is needed.

TRY THIS.

For one week, mark every job you picked up that wasn't planned.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

Who does what? The Money tab

Grace and Ruth, a couple with different incomes

Money (optional)

One line per cost. Put what each person actually paid.

Currency
£ *(pounds)*

Bill	Grace paid (£)	Ruth paid (£)	How it's shared
Rent	1,100	700	*Shared, split*
Power and water	160	0	*Shared, split*
Internet and phones	0	90	*Shared, split*
Groceries	300	250	*Shared, split*

	Grace brings in (£)	Ruth brings in (£)	How it's shared
Pay	4,200	2,800	*Money coming in*

THE SUMMARY

Each person's total: Grace £1,560; Ruth £1,040.

Coming in: £7,000 (Grace £4,200, Ruth £2,800). After shared bills: £4,400 left.

Two ways to split the shared bills. Split evenly: Ruth would put in £260 more · Split by income (60/40): it already comes out even. Pick whichever feels fair to you.

Even isn't always the fair answer (incomes and rooms differ), so treat this as a starting point, not a verdict.

Money is a fair topic only where nobody controls the other's money.
Fill in your own: Who does what? (Money tab)

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Who does what? Count the hours and bills
spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand

03

Fair by promises.

This kind asks whether each person did the jobs they agreed to own. It is clear and steady, and it can feel rigid in a week when life gets in the way. Two business partners run a café, and one owns the ordering while the other owns the staff rota. When the rota is late, they ask the rota owner about it, rather than "the team".

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"It's my job, and I can't do it this week. Could you take it, and I'll take the bins?"

04

Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.

The owner is the person who does the job from start to finish. A second name on the list is a backstop, who notices if it slipped and checks in gently without supervising, and it can be the same person. If the job is yours, the question is whether you did it, and somebody quietly covering for you doesn't answer it. That protects the person who keeps filling the gaps. In one stepfamily the thirteen-year-old owns feeding the dog and his stepmum is the second name. When the bowl is empty at seven, she says "Dog's dinner?" once, without doing it for him and without a lecture.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 9

One owner per job

Dee and Mark, foster carers

One owner per job: caring for a child in care

Person A

Dee

Person B

Mark

Date of this list

4 October 2026

The split you agreed (optional)

Dee works three days; Mark works full time

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Roughly how long?	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Social worker visits	*Monthly*	1.5	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Mark joins by video when he can*
Reviews and meetings	*As needed*	2	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Dee books and preps; Mark comes to the big ones*
Daily log and placement paperwork	*Daily*	0.5	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Mark writes it on Dee's work days*
Contact visits and calls with their family	*Weekly*	1.5	*Mark*	*Dee*	*Saturday mornings*
School liaison (designated teacher, plans)	*As needed*	1	*Dee*		

Job	How often	Roughly how long?	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Being there after contact	*As needed*	1	*Mark*	*Dee*	*Quiet tea, no questions*
Health and therapy appointments	*As needed*	1.5	*Dee*		
Training and support group	*Monthly*	2	*Mark*		*Mark's turn this term*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Jobs with an owner
8 of 8. Every job has an owner.

How the jobs are spread
Counted by how often each job comes round, and by size or time where you gave it: Dee 61% · Mark 39%. You wrote down the split you agreed: "Dee works three days; Mark works full time". Does this match it? It's a starting point for a talk, not a scorecard.

☑ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)
Dee and Mark

"Being there after contact" is on the list because hidden work counts.
Fill in your own: One owner per job (caring for a child in care)

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

05

Covering is kind. Say it out loud.

Helping out when the owner can't is lovely, and it helps to mention it, so that the help is seen, as in "I put the bins out this week, since you were away." Help that stays silent turns into unseen work, and unseen help slowly becomes expected (see Complacency). Two grown-up sisters take turns driving their dad to appointments, and when one covers, she texts the other the same day to say she took Dad on Thursday because of the late shift.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: covering for someone is kind. Say it out loud, gently, and ask for what you'd like next time, so it doesn't turn into quiet resentment.

TOOL **Chat analyzer: Help me write it (ask for a change)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Complacency
spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency

TOOL
Chat analyzer: Help me write it (ask for a change)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

06

Let a comment land before you react.

When a remark hits harder than it should, say “Give me a second.” The idea is borrowed loosely from brain science, where the brain turns down sounds and sensations automatically in a fraction of a second, while this pause is a few seconds you choose to take on purpose. Let the spike pass, then decide whether the remark needs an answer now, later or not at all. A nurse comes home from a night shift and her husband says, “Oh, you’re up.” She hears “at last” and says she needs a second because she is very tired, and it turns out he meant he was glad to see her (see Different hours).

THIS WEEK.

Agree your “give me a second” phrase today, while things are calm.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When a comment stings, give it a minute to land before you answer. This workpaper is a short check for your reply.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · free to print · spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours



WORKPAPER WP-09 · free to print
Say it so it lands
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

07

Notice, name, decide.

First notice that a comment landed hard, then name it kindly, as in "That hit harder than you probably meant," and once you have settled, decide how to reply. Say it so it lands helps with the words. A teenager tells her dad that he never listens. He feels his chest tighten, says that it stings and that he wants to hear her properly, and decides it needs a real talk the next evening, after her swimming.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
>
> "I want to answer that, just not this minute. Can we talk at eight?"

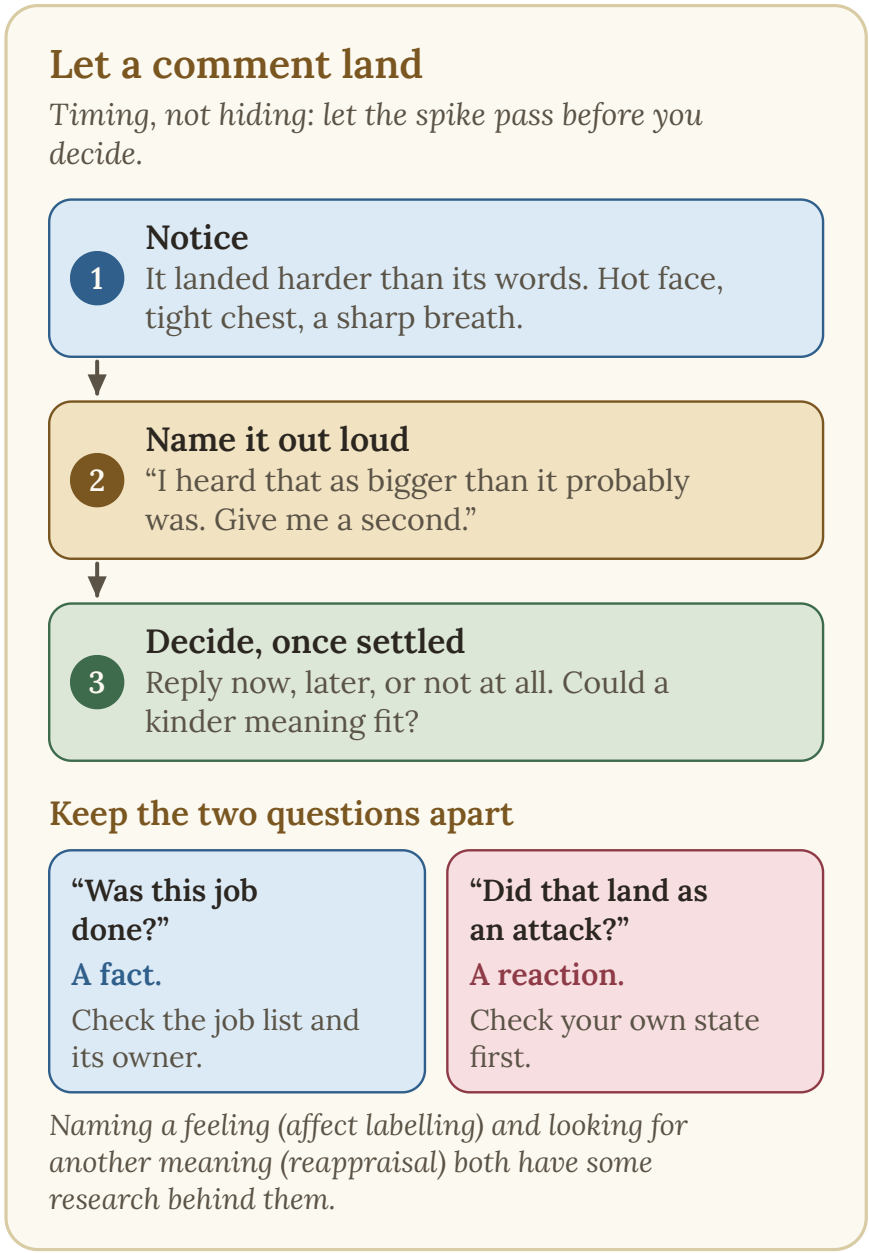


FIGURE 7 Let a comment land before you react: notice, name, decide. And keep the fact question apart from the feeling question.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 10

Say it so it lands

Carla, who runs a café with her business partner Femi

Say it so it lands

Your name

Carla

Date

8 October 2026

Before you speak or send: fact, feeling, ask

Use it on one thing that actually stung.

Raw reaction

Great, so I'm doing the stock order on my own again.

What's the fact underneath this? (One sentence, no adjectives.)

The stock order for the café wasn't placed by Tuesday noon, and I placed it at 4.

What's the feeling underneath this? (Frustrated, tired, unseen, rushed…)

I felt stretched thin, and a bit alone with it.

What's the actual ask? (What do you want to happen next, specifically?)

Could you own the Tuesday stock order from next week, with me as backup when you're at the bank?

Before you react: four quick checks

Is this about a specific, nameable task or event?

(Yes) No

Would I read this the same way if I weren't already carrying a lot?

Yes No (Not sure)

Is there a neutral interpretation that also fits what was said?

(Yes) No

Am I responding to their words, or to a pattern from a past conversation?

Their words A past pattern

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ways to say it
Quick one, no rush: could you own the Tuesday stock order from next week, with me as backup when you're at the bank?

Suggestions
Your own load is part of how this reads. A few hours, or a night's sleep, often changes how it reads. There's a kinder reading that also fits. Try asking about it first: "Did you mean ___, or ___?"

The raw reaction stays on the sheet, not in the message.

Fill in your own: Say it so it lands

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-09 · free to print
Say it so it lands
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

08

Keep the two questions apart.

Whether the job was done is a question about a fact, and whether the comment hurt is a question about a feeling. Both matter, and each goes better in its own conversation. Separated parents share their children across two homes, and the bag

comes back without the school shoes, along with a text about it that felt cold. They sort out the shoes first and talk about the text on Sunday (see Co-parenting).

ONE SMALL STEP.

When a talk tangles, ask “Fact or feeling?” and finish one first.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You control whether, when and how you bring something up, and whether you cover a job out loud. How the other person responds is theirs. If you cover again and again with no thanks and no change, match the energy: cover less, and say so kindly. Fair by promises only works when both people keep theirs. More in Book 1, Chapter 2: who you are today (page 25)

THE WEEKLY CATCH-UP

Sam and Alex share a home. Alex owns the bins but works late on Tuesdays, and Sam has quietly taken them out three weeks running. At the catch-up Sam mentions it, and Alex admits that Tuesday nights aren't realistic with the late shifts. They agree to try a swap for the rest of the month, with Sam taking the bins and Alex taking the recycling and the weekly grocery order, and to settle it at the monthly look-back in Chapter 5 (page 93).

WEDNESDAY, 7PM

"Thanks for doing the dishes," one of you says, a little flatly. It was meant as a thank-you and it sounded like a criticism, and before you know it you have replied to the criticism.

On your own: your own kind of fair

Fair starts with knowing what it means to you and which jobs are truly yours. Write down what fair means to you in one sentence, and list the jobs you own alongside the ones you picked up without ever agreeing to. Olu lives alone and has his children every other weekend, and his sentence is that fair means not doing their jobs just because he misses them (see On my own). Pick one job you took on without agreeing, and either keep it on purpose or raise it on a calm day.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

Common mix-ups

- **"If it got done, there's no problem."** Someone may be paying for it in time and energy.
- **"Holding the owner to it is being strict."** It is keeping the agreement you both made, which is kinder than quiet resentment.
- **"Letting a comment land means ignoring it."** It is about timing, and you still get to answer.
- **"I covered for months, so now I can bring it all up."** A long list lands like a bill, so mention covering as it happens.

Money between you

Money is where the two kinds of fair meet most often. Some couples put everything into one pot. Some keep their money separate and pay agreed bills, often half each, which is fair by promises, the same rule for both. Others each pay into a shared pot in line with what they earn and keep the rest, which is fair by results, since each is left with a similar share. Many couples mix them, with a joint account for bills and food and some money each that nobody has to explain. The right way is the one you both chose with your eyes open. To talk about it, start with your money stories, how money worked at home when you were

growing up, then move on to the numbers and to a "talk first" amount for big purchases that applies to both of you. A limit you both chose and both keep is care, not control.

Niamh takes home £2,600 a month and Tariq £1,900, and their rent and bills will be £1,500. They split it 58/42, in line with their pay, so she pays £870 and he pays £630.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "Can we each say how money worked in our families growing up?" "Would half each, or in line with our pay, feel fairer to you?"

A couple and a housemate

A couple sharing a home with a housemate who isn't a partner is a different shape from three equals. It helps to keep two lists, **house jobs** for all three of you, such as the bins, the bathroom, the bills and the landlord, and **couple jobs** for the two of you. Decide house questions with all three of you there, rather than in bed the night before, hear the housemate first on anything that affects them, keep couple arguments out of shared rooms and never ask them to referee. Ollie and Hamza share a flat with their friend Bex. They split the rent by room, since the couple has the bigger one, and the bills by person, and all three hold a short house meeting on the first Sunday of the month.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "That's a house question. Let's decide it when Bex is here."

More for your situation

Each of these pages takes the ideas in this chapter into one kind of relationship. Start from your relationship lists them all.

- Friends · More than two partners · Sharing a room · Money together
- Foster and kinship families · When a child has ADHD · Grown-up children · Family rifts
- Different hours · Coming home · When one is ill · Two faiths · On my own

On a calm, easy day, each of you can say which kind of fair comes more naturally, results or promises. Then pick three regular jobs and write an owner for each in the job list in One owner per job, with a second name for someone who notices if it slips. Finally, agree a short phrase for when something lands hard, such as "Give me a second", along with the promise that the person who asked for a second will come back to it.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Start from your relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

ONLINE
Friends
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

ONLINE
More than two partners
spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two

TOOL
Plan it once: room agreement for roommates
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

ONLINE
Money together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together

ONLINE
Foster and kinship families
spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship

ONLINE
When a child has ADHD
spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids

ONLINE
Grown-up children
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children

ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts

ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours

ONLINE
Coming home
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home

ONLINE
When one is ill
spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill

ONLINE
Two faiths
spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

A note on safety

These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about what's fair ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A promise is something both people chose and either can ask to change. Rules one person sets for the other, with checking, punishment or money held back, are control, and that is not your fault. See normal limits and control.

WORDS YOU COULD USE, WITH SOMEONE YOU TRUST

"Things at home don't feel fair, and I'm scared to bring it up. Can I talk it through with you?"

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety



ONLINE
normal limits and control
spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **There are two kinds of fair**, by results (did it all get done?) and by promises (did each of us do what we agreed?), so agree which one you are using.
- ✓ **Once a job has an owner, look to the owner**, and when you cover for someone, say so out loud.
- ✓ **Let a comment land before you react** by noticing it, naming it and then deciding what to say.
- ✓ **Keep the two questions apart**, because whether the job was done is a fact and whether the comment hurt is a feeling.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 2, Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt
Repair and apologies that land
Heal and Steady, page 87

Book 3, Chapter 2 · How communication works
Letting words land before you reply
Understanding Each Other, page 27

Book 2, Chapter 7 · Values, meaning and a good life
Fairness as a value you choose together
Heal and Steady, page 121

Book 3, Chapter 6 · Groups, influence and culture
How a group's norms decide what feels fair
Understanding Each Other, page 95

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 4: talk about it kindly
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

Say it so it lands
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4-in-depth

5

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 5

The monthly look-back: a calm relationship check-in

Once a month, look back for the problems that keep coming back, and fix the setup instead of having the same argument again.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Weekly check-ins miss patterns
2. You need four weeks of notes and one list
3. Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped
4. A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner
5. Sort each repeat into one of three kinds
6. Count the gaps each month
7. Look back even when nothing is slipping
8. It's not a review of either person
9. Keep it short and kind
10. A look-back, three months in
11. Common mix-ups
12. Starting out: before you move in
13. Raising a grandchild (kinship care)
14. More for your situation
15. On your own: a monthly look at yourself

THE THIRD TUESDAY IN A ROW

The bins again. You could have the same ten-minute back-and-forth about Tuesday, or you could notice that this has now happened three Tuesdays running and wonder what it is about Tuesdays.

01

Weekly check-ins miss patterns.

One missed job looks like bad luck. The same job missed week after week is a pattern, and patterns are easiest to see when you look at the whole month. The look-back is a careful, friendly glance over that month, closer to a self-check than an inspection. Four flatmates had an overflowing bathroom bin every week, and every week it seemed like bad luck, until they looked at the month together and saw that it had happened every single week since September. Choosing a monthly date now, such as the last Sunday, and putting it in everyone's calendar is the first step.

02

You need four weeks of notes and one list.

Bring the month's four weekly notes from Who did what, where a few lines a week is enough, and your job list from One owner per job. Twenty minutes is usually enough. If either of your stress tanks is high that day, at 0.60 or more on How much are you carrying?, move it a day or two. A couple on different shifts keep their weekly notes in one shared note on their phones and do the look-back on the one evening a month they are both off.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-01 · free to print
Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

03

Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.

A job slipped if it was noticed and not done, only done after being raised more than once, or quietly covered by someone who isn't its owner. Look closely at every job with two or more ✗, because three or four in a month is a real pattern. Two foster carers find that the reading log was missed three weeks out of four. They mark the ✗ in pencil, together, before either of them explains anything.

04

A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner.

Such a problem gets patched every week and never fixed. The owner is the person who does the job from start to finish, so the fix is to give the job one owner whose name sticks, or to talk honestly about whether anyone has the time and energy for it. In a home with three partners, "whoever's free" does the grocery order, and it was late three times this month, because with nobody owning it, everybody assumed someone else had it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 11

One owner per job: a list for two homes

Laura and Dan, co-parents in two homes

One owner per job: a list for two homes

Person A
Laura

Person B
Dan

Date of this list
1 October 2026

The split you agreed (optional)
Week on, week off; handoff Sunday at 5

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Pack the handoff bag	*Weekly*	*Laura*	*Dan*	*Laura keeps the checklist and the spare kit; whoever hands over packs from it*
Send medicine and chargers with the bag	*Weekly*	*Laura*	*Dan*	*Inhaler: write the last dose time on the card*
School forms and permission slips	*As needed*	*Dan*	*Laura*	
Reply to school emails and apps	*Weekly*	*Dan*		*Dan reads them Sunday night*
Kids' doctor and dentist visits	*As needed*	*Dan*		*Dan books; tells Laura the date*
Homework help (Laura's weeks)	*Daily*	*Laura*		
Homework help (Dan's weeks)	*Daily*	*Dan*		
Activities and sign-ups	*As needed*	*Dan*	*Laura*	*Swimming and Cubs*
Buy clothes as they outgrow them	*As needed*	*Laura*		*Receipts in the shared folder*

Job	How often	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Big decisions (school, health, new activities)	*As needed*	*Both (decide together)*		*A decision, not a job: Dan puts it on the list; talked through by phone, never at handoff*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Jobs with an owner
10 of 10. Every job has an owner.

How the jobs sit across the homes
Counted by how often each job comes round (a daily job about five times a weekly one): Laura's home 52% · Dan's home 47% · Together 1%. You wrote down the split you agreed: "Week on, week off; handoff Sunday at 5". Does this match it? Two homes rarely split evenly, and that can be fair: weekdays and weekends, distance and work all play a part.

If one parent is afraid of the other, a shared list isn't the right tool: see Not safe at home? on this site.

Fill in your own: One owner per job (two homes)

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

05

Sort each repeat into one of three kinds.

If a job has no clear owner, update the job list. If its owner can't keep up, have a kind, honest talk. If there was a short-term cause, like illness or travel, note it and move on. Separated parents looking at the missed homework folder ask whether nobody was sure which home signs it, whether one of them is swamped, or whether it was simply the week she had flu (see Co-parenting).

The monthly look-back

Which gaps kept reopening, however often we closed them?

1 Mark the month

	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4
Recycling	✗	✗	✗	✗
Bins	✗	✗	·	✗
School forms	·	✗	·	·
Dog's walk	·	·	·	·

The ✗ goes next to a job, never next to a person.

2 Sort each repeat

Structural gap
No clear owner, or the wrong name on the list. → **Update the job list.**

Capacity issue
An owner who has run out of room. → **Set a time for a kind talk.**

One-off
A clear short-term reason: illness, travel. → **Note it and move on.**

3 Count, and close the month

Fewer structural gaps over several months is a good sign. Zero isn't the goal.

Short and kind. A look at the setup, not a review of either person.

This book's own method, adapted from team "retrospectives"; it hasn't been tested as a household method.

FIGURE 8 The monthly look-back: mark the month, sort each repeat, count and close. The cross goes next to a job, never a person.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 12

What keeps coming back?

Ash, Robin and Jules, a triad sharing a home

What keeps coming back?

Person A
Ash

Person B
Robin

Person C
Jules

Month
September 2026

Part A: Gather the month's notes

Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped. ✗ = it slipped that week.

Task	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4	Times flagged
Cat litter	✗	✗		✗	3
Recycling out on Thursday		✗	✗		2
Book Jules's car service			✗		1
Shared calendar kept up to date	✗	✗	✗	✗	4

Part B: Sort each gap

Sort every task flagged twice or more.

Task	Named owner on the job list?	Classification	Action
Cat litter	*No*	*Structural gap*	*Robin owns it, with Ash as backup; on the one-owner list tonight*
Shared calendar kept up to date	*Yes*	*Capacity issue*	*Ash owns it but is on nights this month; talk on Sunday about what comes off Ash's list*
Recycling out on Thursday	*Yes*	*One-off, no action*	*Two bank holidays moved the day*

PART C: WRAP UP THE AUDIT

Structural gaps found

1. Update One owner per job for each of these in this session.

Capacity issues found

1. Set a time for the conversation. This audit brings it to light, but it doesn't replace it.

One-offs

1

Part D (optional): Thanked, or only noticed when it's missed?

Job	Gets thanked	Only noticed when missed?	One way to notice it
Keeping the calendar	*Rarely*	*Yes*	*Say thanks at Sunday dinner when it's up to date*
Topping up the cat food	*Never*	*Yes*	*A note on the fridge*

A task with no owner is a gap in the setup, not a verdict on the person

who kept covering it.

Fill in your own: What keeps coming back?

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting



WORKPAPER WP-04 · free to print
What keeps coming back?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

06

Count the gaps each month.

Write down how many gaps of each kind you found. If the number of jobs with no clear owner falls over several months, the setup is working, and a single month can be a normal swing. If it keeps rising, something bigger has changed and it is worth a talk. Two business partners write their monthly count on a whiteboard in the back office. In March four jobs had no clear owner, and by June one did.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The look-back has its own workpaper: a month of notes, one list, and an ✗ for each week a job slipped. It makes a pattern easy to see.

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · free to print · spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-04 · free to print
What keeps coming back?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

07

Look back even when nothing is slipping.

A month with no gaps is good news, and it is also the month most likely to go unchecked. When something has worked for a while, people stop looking, and nothing breaks on the day that happens. Keep the look-back going in quiet months and add one question, "*What's something we've stopped noticing or mentioning*?", which is how a look-back guards against complacency. The children have left home and nothing is slipping, and at the look-back one of them says that they don't really talk at dinner any more.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
complacency
spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency

08

It's not a review of either person.

You don't add up old hours or punish old mistakes. You can thank someone for what they carried before, and you leave the past unbilled. The only question is where the setup isn't working yet and what you will try next month. After a month in hospital, one partner comes home to a long list of what slipped, and they thank each other for what each carried and set up only the month ahead.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: a look-back can start with a high five. Name one thing that went well first! The weekly card has a nice way to begin.

TOOL **Kitchen-table check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Kitchen-table check-in
spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

09

Keep it short and kind.

Start with something that went well and talk about the job instead of the person. If a gap needs a proper talk, set it for another day using Check-ins. If a talk starts going badly, either of you can call a pause, and whoever paused names a time to come back. A mum and two teenagers hold their look-back over pizza. Each says one good thing first, one gap gets a new owner, and it is over in fifteen minutes.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 13

Kitchen-table check-in: this week

Linda and her grown-up son Jordan, who live together

Our weekly check-in

Week of Oct 5 · Linda and Jordan

Who's checking in (optional)
Linda and Jordan

One thing that went well
Jordan cooked twice, and we ate together on Thursday.

One thing that felt heavy
The bathroom, again. And Mum's back was bad all week.

One small thing to try next week
Jordan owns the bathroom on Saturdays. Linda stops checking it.

Our next check-in
Sunday after dinner

Any jobs that slipped or came up again this week? (optional)

Dishes · Laundry · Trash and recycling · Groceries · Cooking · *Cleaning the bathroom* · Paying the bills · Planning and remembering

ON THE CARD

One topic at a time. We're on the same side. Tick a job once it has one owner.

Fill in your own: Kitchen-table check-in: this week

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Kitchen-table check-in
spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. In the look-back you can only fix the gaps you own, and offer help with the rest. You can't make someone keep a rhythm. Keep the rhythms you can keep, notice which ones are kept in return, and let your effort follow: more where it's shared, less where it isn't, so the rhythm doesn't run on one person's energy. More in Book 1, Chapter 2: who you are today (page 25)

THE LAST SUNDAY OF THE MONTH

Two mugs of tea, four weeks of notes and twenty minutes. You go down the list together. Most weeks went fine, and two jobs keep coming up, the recycling and the call to the landlord, so you give each of them a name and finish your tea.

A look-back, three months in

Sam and Alex's bins slipped three weeks in a row because Alex works late on Tuesdays. After the trial swap they make it official, so Sam owns the bins and Alex takes the recycling and the weekly grocery order, which keeps the hours even. The second month is clean. In the third, the grocery order slips twice, both times in a week when Alex's mother was in hospital, and they mark it as a one-off and leave the list alone. What changes in

month three is that Alex mentions, almost in passing, that he has stopped enjoying their Saturday mornings, which no list had shown, and they agree to talk about it properly on Thursday.

YOU COULD SAY

"I don't think anyone dropped this. I think nobody ever picked it up."

Common mix-ups

- **"This is where we settle who owes what."** Past hours are never billed to anyone, though you can still say thank you for them, and you only fix the setup going forward.
- **"If a job slipped, the owner failed."** The gap might be in the list, in the owner's capacity or in one unusual week.
- **"We can skip the weekly checks and just do this."** The monthly look-back only works if the weekly notes feed it.

A note on safety: These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If looking back together ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? lists free, private hotlines.

A look-back is something you both choose. If one person demands logs of the other's every hour, checks their phone without agreement, or uses the ✗ marks to punish, that is control, not a look-back, and it is not your fault. See Not safe at home? and normal limits and control (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together).

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety



ONLINE
normal limits and control
spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together

Starting out: before you move in

If you are new together and about to share a home, the tools work best now, before habits set, at about one step a week. In the first week, each of you writes down the rulebook from the home you grew up in and then you swap, with curiosity. In the second, talk about money, starting with your money stories and moving on to the split (Chapter 4 (page 85)). In the third, write your first job list, with one owner per job and the thinking jobs included (One owner per job), and in the fourth, make a pause plan on a calm day. In the fifth, each name three things that matter most to you about a home (Book 2, Chapter 7 (page 121)). After the move, log one ordinary week once two weeks have passed, and do your first short look-back after four. None of it is a test, and the point is that neither of you has to guess.

Niamh and Tariq, eight months together, find that their families meant different things by “tidy”, and they agree on the kitchen every night and the rest on Sunday.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
rulebook from the home you grew up in
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up



WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03



ONLINE
a pause plan
spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw

Raising a grandchild (kinship care)

Many grandparents and other relatives raise a child whose parents can't, and much of it involves things that keep coming back, such as cancelled calls, hard evenings after contact and forms. A monthly look-back helps. Some repeats you can own, and some, like a parent who misses calls, you can't, and for those you can own the plan for the evening after. The child may love both the parent who can't look after them and you, so tell them they don't have to choose, and don't run the parent down in front of them. Explain an absent parent in short, true and kind words for their age, always with the message that it isn't their fault. When the parent is your own adult child and things are hard between you, keep messages about the child short and civil for the child's sake, and leave the door open. Look after yourself too, by asking for respite and joining other kinship carers. In England and Wales, the charity Kinship (kinship.org.uk) can help.

Maureen, who is sixty-three, is raising her grandson Tyler, who is nine. Her look-back shows that his mum's Sunday call fell through three times this month, so she plans those evenings with hot chocolate and his football annual, and asks her brother to take Tyler swimming on Sunday afternoons.

WORDS YOU COULD USE, WITH THE CHILD

"Mum loves you. She isn't well enough to look after you right now, and that's not your fault."

More for your situation

A look-back works in every kind of relationship, with small changes. Start from your relationship lists pages for each one.

- More than two partners · Money together · Gaming and time together · Sharing a room
- Foster and kinship families · When a child has ADHD · Grown-up children · Family rifts · Kids grown and gone
- Different hours · Coming home · When one is ill · Two faiths · On my own · For counsellors

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Start from your relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship



ONLINE
More than two partners
spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two



ONLINE
Money together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together



ONLINE
Gaming and time together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together



TOOL
Plan it once: room agreement for roommates
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room



ONLINE
Foster and kinship families
spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship



ONLINE
When a child has ADHD
spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids



ONLINE
Grown-up children
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children



ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts



ONLINE
Kids grown and gone
spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest



ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours



ONLINE
Coming home
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home



ONLINE
When one is ill
spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill



ONLINE
Two faiths
spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own



ONLINE
For counsellors
spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors

On your own: a monthly look at yourself

Once a month, look back at your own month kindly, more like a weather report than a scorecard. Ask what filled your battery

and what drained it, which of your limits held and which slipped, and choose one small thing to keep and one to change. Gillian lives on her own after a divorce, and her look-back shows the same ✗ three weeks running, because she skipped her Thursday swim to answer work emails, so she moves the emails and keeps the swim (see On my own).

To begin, put a relaxed twenty-minute date in the calendar once a month and keep your weekly notes somewhere you can both find them. At the look-back, start by naming one thing that went well, and end by writing down how many gaps of each kind you found, so that over the next few months you can see whether the number is falling. What keeps coming back? is the workpaper for that conversation.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own



WORKPAPER WP-04 · free to print
What keeps coming back?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Weekly check-ins miss patterns.
- ✓ Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.
- ✓ Sort each repeat into one of three kinds.
- ✓ Look back even when nothing is slipping.
- ✓ Keep it short and kind.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1, Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming
The same kind look, on your own
Know Yourself Kindly, page 45

Book 2, Chapter 6 · Habits and change
Why problems come back, and how habits stick
Heal and Steady, page 105

Chapter 2 · Is the split working?
The setup score the look-back feeds
page 27

Book 2, Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt
Repairing what the look-back finds
Heal and Steady, page 87

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 6: make it last
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

What keeps coming back? A monthly look-back
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5-in-depth

BOOK 4 · AFTERWORD

What the series adds up to

A short look back over the whole series: what each of the four books was for, the few ideas that run through all of them, and where to go next.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Four books, one idea
2. Six threads through the series
3. Where to go from here

IN SHORT

- **Book 1 was about you**, where your lens came from, how you are wired and who you are becoming.
- **Book 2 was about steadying yourself** through stress, anger, worry, grief and change.
- **Book 3 was about understanding the people around you**, from how words land to why groups pull so hard.
- **Book 4 was about sharing the work of a shared life**, fairly and without keeping score.
- **One thread runs through all four**, which is to notice before you judge, settle before you speak, say it plainly, take small steps, repair, and keep everyone safe.

You don't need to have read all four books, or even all of this one, to get something from these last pages. Most people read in the order their life asks for, and the books were written so that you could start anywhere, stop anywhere and pick them up again a year later.

Four books, one idea

Know Yourself Kindly came first because everything else depends on it. It looked at the lens you see through, at where your lens came from (Book 1, Chapter 1, page 9) and how you are wired today (Book 1, Chapter 2, page 25), and at how feelings, worth, personality and different minds work. It is hard to share a life well without some idea of how you work yourself.

Heal and Steady was for the heavy days. It explained what stress does to the body (Book 2, Chapter 1, page 9), what anger is for, how worry and low mood work and where to find help, and it walked through grief, repair, change and what matters to you.

Understanding Each Other turned outwards, to why two kind people fall out of tune, how a message travels from one mind to another, why two people see the same moment so differently (Book 3, Chapter 3, page 45), and how belonging, love, groups and helping work.

Share the Load, this book, looked at the quiet work of running a home, a family or a team, at how to see it, share it fairly and talk about it without blame.

Underneath all four sits one idea. Most of what goes wrong between people can be understood, and much of it can be put right, mainly by seeing a little more clearly and acting a little more kindly, a little more often.

Six threads through the series

The five big ideas described at the front of each book (*see the whole load*, *fix the setup, not the person*, *read your state first*, *tune how you send and receive* and *notice the quiet incentives*) turn into a handful of everyday habits, with one rule around all of them.

01

Notice before you judge.

A sharp word, a forgotten job or a quiet evening usually has a reason, whether tiredness, a full stress tank, a different family rule or a different kind of mind. Asking what might be going on before deciding what is wrong with someone changes most conversations. How we see each other (Book 3, Chapter 3, page 45) goes into this.

02

Settle before you speak.

When the body is flooded, nobody listens well, so slow your breathing, step away with a time to come back, and then talk. Stress and the nervous system (Book 2, Chapter 1, page 9) and Anger (Book 2, Chapter 2, page 31) show how.

03

Say it plainly and kindly.

Say what happened, how it felt and what you are asking for, because clear words are kind to everyone involved. How communication works (Book 3, Chapter 2, page 27) has the details.

04

Small steps beat big pushes.

One job with one owner, one walk or one message is how change that lasts usually starts, small and repeated. Habits and change (Book 2, Chapter 6, page 105) and Is the split working? (Chapter 2, page 27) both rest on this.

05

Repair is normal.

Everyone gets it wrong sometimes. What keeps relationships going is coming back with a short, real apology and a plan for next time, as Healing after hurt (Book 2, Chapter 5, page 87) describes.

06

Your part, and only your part. Safety first.

You can change what you do. You can't make anyone else change, and you never have to accept being frightened, controlled or hurt. If that's happening, getting safe comes before working it out. See Not safe at home?

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/safety

Where to go from here

On your own, the self path turns Book 1 into a few steps you can take at your own pace. With someone else, the six-week program turns this book into one small step a week, for a home, a family or a team, and it doesn't mind if you miss a week. If you have a question about anything in the series, Professor Puddles answers on the website. The research behind this book lists every study the series draws on, in plain words, with how strong the evidence is, and every chapter has a fuller version online, listed at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book. When it is more than a book can help with, Help beyond this book lists counsellors, helplines and support groups.

ANY DAY, ANY TIME

You close the book. Nothing at home has changed yet, and the post is probably still on the table. The next time a sharp word lands, though, you might wonder what is under it, or breathe out before you answer, or say the thing plainly, or say sorry a little sooner. Thank you for reading.

This book is general education, not therapy. If you are struggling, please reach out: someone to talk to, free.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
the self path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



ONLINE
the six-week program
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



TOOL
Ask Professor Puddles
spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask



ONLINE
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/



ONLINE
Help beyond this book
spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help



ONLINE
someone to talk to, free
spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1, Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from
Start again at the beginning, on your own
Know Yourself Kindly, page 9

Chapter 1 · The work nobody sees
Start the shared part, with someone
page 9

Book 1, Chapter 4 · How feelings work
Start the background chapters
Know Yourself Kindly, page 61

PUT IT TO USE

The self path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

The six-week program
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/afterword-in-depth

Your first month, week by week

If you would like an order to follow, here is one. Each week takes a few minutes a day at most, and a missed week is fine. The six-week program on the website does the same at a gentler pace.

WHEN	WHAT TO DO	READ MORE	DONE
Week 1	See the work. Each of you fills in Who did what for one ordinary week, writing only what you did yourself.	The work nobody sees (Chapter 1, page 9)	☐
Week 2	Give every job a name. Go through the job list on the next pages together and use One owner per job to agree an owner for each.	Is the split working? (Chapter 2, page 27)	☐
Week 3	Check the tanks. Each of you fills in How much are you carrying? on two or three days, then work out the setup score with the setup calculator or on paper.	Full tanks and different angles (Chapter 3, page 49)	☐
Week 4	Look back together. Sit down for twenty minutes with What keeps coming back?, choose one small change, and put the next look-back in the diary.	The monthly look-back (Chapter 5, page 93)	☐

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
six-week program
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

WORKPAPER WP-01 · free to print
Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

TOOL
Fair split check: this week
spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working

WORKPAPER WP-04 · free to print
What keeps coming back?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

A list of jobs to start from

Most homes share some of these. Tick the ones that happen in yours, cross out the rest and add your own at the bottom. Then give each ticked job one owner and, if you like, a backstop who notices if it slips, as in Is the split working? (Chapter 2, page 27) The same list is in the Quick look tool on the website, under Who does what? Quick look, and the workpaper One owner per job has room for the names.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Who does what? Quick look
spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand



WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

☐ happens in our home ..... owner

HOME AND FOOD

- [ ] Dishes and the kitchen reset
- [ ] Washing and drying
- [ ] Folding and putting away
- [ ] Changing the sheets
- [ ] Cleaning the bathroom
- [ ] Vacuuming and floors
- [ ] Tidying up
- [ ] Bins and recycling
- [ ] Cooking dinner
- [ ] Meal planning
- [ ] Grocery shopping
- [ ] Packing lunches
- [ ] Restocking soap, paper and supplies
- [ ] Small fixes around the home
- [ ] Plants and the garden

MONEY AND ADMIN

- [ ] Paying bills
- [ ] Budget and checking accounts
- [ ] Taxes and receipts
- [ ] Post and home email
- [ ] Phone calls and customer service
- [ ] Insurance and documents
- [ ] Renewals and switching plans
- [ ] The car

CHILDREN

- [ ] Getting the kids up and ready
- [ ] School or nursery runs
- [ ] Homework help
- [ ] Bath time
- [ ] Bedtime
- [ ] Driving to activities
- [ ] School forms and sign-ups
- [ ] Playdates and parties
- [ ] Night wakings
- [ ] Childcare and backup plans

CARE AND HEALTH

- [ ] Booking appointments
- [ ] Medicines and refills
- [ ] Health appointments and calls
- [ ] Being on call for someone who is unwell
- [ ] Personal care (washing, dressing)

PETS

- [ ] Feeding the pets
- [ ] Dog walks
- [ ] Litter, cage or tank
- [ ] Vet visits and pet supplies

FAMILY AND FRIENDS

- [ ] Keeping up with both families
- [ ] Birthdays and holidays
- [ ] Gifts and cards
- [ ] Hosting visitors
- [ ] Planning time with friends
- [ ] Planning trips and holidays

THE THINKING WORK

- [ ] Noticing what's running low
- [ ] Planning the week
- [ ] Remembering dates and appointments
- [ ] Keeping the family calendar
- [ ] Keeping track of the kids' stuff
- [ ] Checking that things got done
- [ ] Checking in on how people are

YOUR OWN

- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]

Words for the talk

Some ways to say the hard parts, collected in one place. Change the words until they sound like you.

TO BEGIN

> "Can we look at how the week went, together? I'd like us both to see it."
>
> "I've written down what I did this week. Would you do the same, so we can compare?"
>
> "Is now a good time, or would after dinner be better?"
>
> "I think a lot of the remembering lands on me. Can we talk about that?"

WHEN IT GETS TENSE

> "I'm getting wound up. Can we stop for twenty minutes and come back at eight?"
>
> "That came out sharper than I meant. Let me try again."
>
> "My tank is pretty full today, so I might sound crosser than I feel."
>
> "What did you hear me say?"

HANDING OVER A JOB

> "Could you own the bins from now on, from noticing they're full to putting them out?"
>
> "It's yours now, so do it your way. I'll only step in if you ask."
>
> "I'll be the backstop this month. If it slips, I'll mention it once, gently."

SAYING NO KINDLY

> "That's a fair ask. I can't take it on this week, but I could do Saturday's shop instead."
>
> "I'm at my limit. Can we look at what else could drop?"

THANKS AND CHECKING IN

> "Thanks for sorting the dentist. I noticed."
>
> "What's one thing that felt easier this month?"
>
> "Is anything from last week still sitting with you?"

Questions people ask

Some questions this book tends to raise, with short answers and where to read more.

My partner thinks the split is already fair. Where do we start?

With a week of facts. Fill in Who did what for one ordinary week, each of you writing only what you did yourself, and look at it together over a cup of tea. The planning and remembering often surprises both people. The work nobody sees (Chapter 1, page 9) explains why, and Is the split working? (Chapter 2, page 27) has a part for when only one of you wants to try.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-01 · free to print
Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

There are three or more of us. Does any of this still work?

Yes. Housemates, families with older children and teams can all use the same pages. Compare each person's share with an even share, which is 100 divided by the number of people, or with the split you agreed. "How the numbers work" at the back of this book (page 131) shows the sums.

One of us works much longer paid hours. Is it fair to count only housework?

It isn't, and the book doesn't. If you have agreed an uneven split at home because one of you works longer hours outside it, the setup score compares against that agreement instead of an even split. Two kinds of fair (Chapter 4, page 69) explains the difference between fair by results and fair by promises.

Can children have jobs with an owner too?

They can own jobs that suit their age, with an adult as the backstop who notices if it slips. Owning one small job from start to finish, such as feeding the cat or packing a school bag, is a good first step. Keep the planning and remembering with the adults until a child is ready for a piece of it, and say thank you out loud.

Talking about chores always turns into a row. What can we do?

Pick a calm time, never the moment something has been left undone. Check how full each of your stress tanks is first, because a full tank makes every word land harder. Full tanks and different angles (Chapter 3, page 49) shows how, and The monthly look-back (Chapter 5, page 93) gives you a short, regular time to talk so that nothing has to wait for an argument.

Does this work at work, in a team?

Yes. The same quiet jobs exist at work, such as booking the room, chasing the late reply and noticing that the printer is out of paper, and a named owner and a real thank-you help there too. Most of the pages in this book work for a team with the word “home” swapped for “work”.

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool the chapters point to, in two separate lists, with the chapters that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill in, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01
In: The work nobody sees (page 9)

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 49)

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03
In: Is the split working? (page 27)

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04
In: The monthly look-back (page 93)

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09
In: Two kinds of fair (page 69)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **Kitchen-table check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins
In: The monthly look-back (page 93)

TOOL **Chat analyzer: Help me write it (ask for a change)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins
In: Two kinds of fair (page 69)

TOOL **Who does what? Quick look** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand`
In: The work nobody sees (page 9)

TOOL **My weather today** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks`
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 49)

TOOL **Fair split check: this week** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working`
In: Is the split working? (page 27)

How the numbers work

Every number in this book is arithmetic you can do with a pencil. None of them is a test, a diagnosis or a verdict on anyone: they describe a week, a load or a way of sharing work. The weights and cut-offs are this book's own rules of thumb, not research findings, and you are free to disagree with them. The worked examples are the book's own, so you can check them against the chapters.

Two habits run through all of them. **Scores are rounded to two decimal places before their band is read,** so the number you see and the words you see always agree. And **nobody's score is ever worked out for them:** if someone's own answer is missing, the total waits.

The stress tank: How much are you carrying?

You score five things from 0 (not at all) to 4 (very true), about the last day or two: sleep debt, workload elsewhere, unresolved conflict, your physical state, and time pressure today.

```
tank = (sleep + workload + conflict + body + time) ÷ 20
```

The answer runs from 0 to 1, and **higher means fuller**. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 medium, and 0.60 or more high. (The worksheet splits each band in two for its words: very light under 0.15, light, medium on the lighter side under 0.45, medium on the heavier side, high under 0.80, and very high from 0.80.) Your **battery** is the other side of the same thing, the energy you have left, so a full tank means a low battery. The battery is a picture in words, not a second score.

> WORKED EXAMPLE Rosa, from Chapter 3, page 49, scores sleep 3, workload 4, conflict 1, body 2 and time 3.
>
> `3 + 4 + 1 + 2 + 3 = 13; 13 ÷ 20 = 0.65`, which is in the high band.

Two or more of you: each person scores only themselves, and the shared figure is the plain average of everyone's own scores. If any one person is at 0.60 or more, treat that as the headline, whatever the average says.

Coming back after a pause (the Calm-Down Kit): if you like numbers, take the score again after a calming round. Under 0.50, go back at the time you named. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round. At 0.60 or more after two rounds, put it off to a named time. The kit's line sits at 0.50 on purpose: you don't need an empty tank to come back, just one less than half full.

My weather today: the room in your day

My weather today shows words, not numbers: a sky (clear, gusty or fogged in) and how much room you have today. Behind the words sits a rough tally from 0 to 100, where **higher means a heavier day**. You only see it if you tick "Show the numbers behind this".

WHAT YOU PICKED	ADDS
The sky: clear, gusty, fogged in	0, 26, 34
The pressure: light, building, heavy (skipped: 6)	0, 10, 20
Last night's sleep: properly rested, about enough, short night, barely slept (skipped: 6)	0, 2, 10, 18
People load: barely any, a normal amount, a lot, nonstop (skipped: 4)	0, 3, 9, 14
Ground conditions (hungry, thirsty, in pain and so on)	4 each, up to 14
What's blowing in (work, money, health and so on)	3 each, up to 10

Under 45 reads as lots of room today, 45 to 64 as some room, and 65 or more as very little room.

WORKED EXAMPLE Joel, from Book 1, Chapter 2, page 25, picks gusty, building pressure, a short night, a lot of people time, one ground condition (hungry) and one thing blowing in (work).

`26 + 10 + 10 + 9 + 4 + 3 = 62`: some room today, with less than usual, so the forecast says to go gently and settle first.

Workload balance: how evenly the hours are shared

Two people. Work out each person's share of the logged hours as a percentage.

```
balance = 1 − (the difference between the two percentages ÷
100)
```

50/50 scores 1.00; one person doing everything scores 0.00. It doesn't matter which of you does more. Balance ignores the total, which is one reason the stress tank sits beside it.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary logs 14 hours and Ken 10 (Chapter 2, page 27). Out of 24 hours, that is 58.3% and 41.7%.

`1 − (58.3 − 41.7) ÷ 100 = 1 − 0.167 = 0.83`

Three or more people, or an agreed split. The same idea, said more generally: how much of the week would have to change hands to reach the target, compared with the most that ever could.

```
each share = that person's hours ÷ everyone's hours
target     = an even share (1 ÷ number of people), or the split
you agreed
moved      = ½ × the sum of every |share − target|
most       = 1 − the smallest target share
balance    = 1 − moved ÷ most
```

WORKED EXAMPLE Three partners log 15, 9 and 6 hours (Chapter 2, page 27): shares 0.50, 0.30 and 0.20, against a third each.

`moved = ½ × (0.167 + 0.033 + 0.133) = 0.167; most = 1 − 0.333 = 0.667; balance = 1 − 0.167 ÷ 0.667 = 0.75`. In hours, 0.167 × 30 = 5 hours a week would change hands for an even split.

With an agreed split, use it as the target: co-parents who agreed 60/40 and log 12 and 8 hours score 1.00.

Ownership: does every job have a name?

```
ownership = jobs with a named owner ÷ all the jobs on the list
```

The calculator counts a job as owned when it has one named owner. A backstop, the person who notices if it slipped, is a good habit and has its own column, but the score only needs the owner. The starter jobs on the worksheet don't count until you give them an owner or change them. Never raise the score by deleting the jobs nobody owns: they are exactly what the score is there to show.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken list 12 regular jobs, and 9 have an owner: `9 ÷ 12 = 0.75`.

Who carries more of the list. A score of 1.00 can still mean one person owns everything, so One owner per job also shows each person's share of the list, with each job weighted by how often it comes round and how big it is:

```
weight of a job = how often × size
how often: daily 5, weekly 1, ongoing 1, monthly 0.25, as
needed 0.1
size:      small 0.5, medium 1 (the default), big 2
           (or, where you gave the hours each time: hours ÷
0.5)
share      = the weights of that person's jobs ÷ the weights of
all the jobs
```

A job you decide together counts the same for each of you; on a list for two homes it shows as "Together" instead.

WORKED EXAMPLE One person owns the cooking (daily, medium: 5) and the bills (monthly, medium: 0.25). The other owns the laundry (weekly, big: 2) and the car (as needed, medium: 0.1). Each owns two jobs, but `5.25 ÷ 7.35 = 71%` of the list's weight sits with the first person, and 29% with the second.

Who's carrying more right now. Who did what flags the busiest person when their share of the logged minutes (or of the work done without being asked) is at least half, and at least 20 points over an even share: 70% or more for two people, 53% or more for three. In the Chapter 1, page 9's example, one partner did 105 of the 115 minutes that were noticed and handled without anyone asking: 91%, so the sheet says so.

The setup score: can the way you share the work last?

```
setup score = balance × 0.40
            + ownership × 0.35
            + (1 − the average tank score) × 0.25
```

The weights add up to 1, so the score runs from 0 to 1, and here **higher means the setup is working better**, the opposite of the tank score. The tank is the only part that counts against the score, which is why it enters as 1 − tank. 0.70 or more reads as working well (the "Who does what?" page says "holding"); 0.40 up to 0.70 as needs a look ("drifting"); below 0.40 as needs a rethink, together. It is a snapshot of the setup, never a probability and never a verdict on anyone.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken (Chapter 2, page **27**): balance 0.83, ownership 0.75, and their own tank scores are 0.45 and 0.30, an average of 0.375.

`0.83 × 0.40 + 0.75 × 0.35 + (1 − 0.375) × 0.25 = 0.333 + 0.263 + 0.156 = 0.75`: working well.

The shortfall is what each part could have earned minus what it did earn: balance 0.40 − 0.333 = 0.067; ownership 0.35 − 0.263 = 0.088; tank 0.25 − 0.156 = 0.094. The biggest shortfall is the tank, which usually eases outside the chore list (more sleep, a lighter week elsewhere). The calculator's "what would help most" is the single change with the biggest gain: handing about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken would take balance from 0.83 to 1.00, worth 0.067. Naming one more job's owner would be worth 0.029, and a tank score lower by 0.10 on average 0.025.

The 30-day look-back: what shifted this month?

The look-back splits the last 30 days into four weeks (the first takes the first ten days). For each part you filled in (balance, ownership, the stress tank, and last-minute rescues), it compares the start of the month with the end:

```
start = the average of weeks 1 and 2
end   = the average of weeks 3 and 4
it shifted if end − start is 0.10 or more (balance, ownership,
tank),
           or 1 a week or more (rescues); anything smaller
didn't shift
```

One next step: a part that moved the wrong way comes first (the biggest move for its size). Otherwise, the first of these that is still true at the end: ownership under 0.70, balance under 0.70, 2 or more rescues a week, or anyone's tank at 0.60 or more. If none is, keep the same rhythm and look again in 30 days.

Hours to change hands over the month: for each person, the hours they did minus their share of everyone's hours, added up week by week. Half the sum of those gaps (ignoring the minus signs) is how many hours would change hands to make the month even.

WORKED EXAMPLE Suppose Rosemary and Ken keep going for a month (made up, like them). Their four weeks: hours 14 and 10, 15 and 9, 13 and 11, 12 and 12; jobs with an owner 9, 9, 11 and 11 of 12; Rosemary's tank 0.45, 0.50, 0.40, 0.35 and Ken's 0.30 every week; rescues 3, 2, 1, 1.

PART	START (WEEKS 1–2)	END (WEEKS 3–4)	CHANGE	READS AS
Balance	(0.83 + 0.75) ÷ 2 = 0.79	(0.92 + 1.00) ÷ 2 = 0.96	+0.17	Better
Ownership	0.75	0.92	+0.17	Better
Average tank score	0.39	0.34	−0.05	About the same
Rosemary's own tank	0.48	0.38	−0.10	Lighter
Rescues a week	2.5	1	−1.5	Fewer

Three of the four parts shifted, all for the better, and nothing is left on the watch list, so the next step is to keep the rhythm. The setup score went from 0.73 to 0.87. Over the month Rosemary did 54 hours and Ken 42, so 6 hours would have changed hands for an even month.

On your own: is your week sustainable?

The “Who does what?” page’s “just me” view adds up the hours your week is spoken for (jobs, the thinking work, care and so on) and compares them with a waking week of about 112 hours (16 waking hours, 7 days).

```
share = the hours spoken for ÷ 112
```

Under 50% reads as sustainable, 50% up to 70% as full but workable, and 70% or more as stretched. For example, 50 hours spoken for is 45%, which leaves real room; 80 hours is 71%, a lot to keep up week after week.

All of these are this book’s own ways of putting things into numbers. They have not been tested in research studies, and they shouldn’t be quoted as findings. The free calculators on the website do the arithmetic for you, and each one has a “How is this worked out?” note.

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Backstop

The second name on a job: someone who notices if it slipped and checks in kindly. Not a supervisor. A job counts as owned once it has an owner; the backstop is a good habit on top.

Battery

Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, your load: a higher load score means a heavier load, and a lower battery.

Calm-Down Kit

The Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

Check-in

A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

Complacency

Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

Flooded

Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

Frequency

Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

Gatekeeping

Holding on to how a home or child-care job must be done, so the other person steps back. Researchers first described it in mothers ("maternal gatekeeping"), but anyone can do it.

Kinship care

When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

The ladder

Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

Ledger

A notebook where you write down what happened, so you can look at it calmly later. The book works the same way: see what is really going on, without blame, then change one small thing.

The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

Mental load

The noticing, planning and remembering behind running a shared life: knowing the shoes are too small, booking the appointment, keeping the list. It is real work, even though nobody sees it.

My weather today

My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

Parallel parenting

Co-parenting with as little direct contact as possible: each home runs its own way, and messages stay short, polite and about the children.

Person A and Person B

Person A and Person B are simply the two people on a two-person worksheet or tool. They are labels, not a ranking.

Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

The rulebook from home

The rulebook from home is the unwritten set of rules you grew up with, about love, upset, chores and rest, that you may still expect others to follow.

Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 to 0.59 moderate, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

Unbilled debt

Unbilled debt is the work of a shared life that got done but was never noticed or thanked.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

Workpaper

A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

Research notes

The 68 studies and books these chapters mention, in short. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online: `spreadloveandacceptance.com/research`.

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